A Series of Dusks

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A Nightmare

COL-600901

A Series of Dusks

Secret Cabin

Team Member I: Target not in Building 2!

Team Member II: Confirmed, target not in vicinity of the house!

Semmelweis: They're not here.

Semmelweis: Our intel was wrong. We were set up.

"Razor": A fenébe!

"Razor" swings his hand in frustration knocking a hole clean through a wooden bookshelf.

The notes lying on the shelf fall and scatter.

Semmelweis: Calm yourself, "Razor." Tearing up this place won't get us anywhere closer to our target.

Semmelweis: This "Beyond" has been alive for over two hundred years. It's a living legend, we knew it couldn't be this easy.

"Razor" pulls his arm out, breathing out steadily.

"Razor": You're right. I lost my composure.

Semmelweis: I am not one to admit defeat, but we are out of time to contain this vampire.

Semmelweis: We need to go back to the Foundation; we can't afford to take risks with the "Storm."

"Razor": We know so little about this vampire's arcane skill. It has made it next to impossible to track.

Semmelweis: Which is all the more reason to hunt it.

Semmelweis: All that aside, our operation wasn't entirely fruitless.

Semmelweis bends down to pick up the papers now lying on the ground before the shelf.

She scans the page, absorbed in thought.

"Razor": What does it say?

Semmelweis: It's an old bill.

Semmelweis: The Laplace researchers might be interested in this. At the very least, it could help us study the dietary habits of vampires.

Semmelweis: "Record of Delivery," a "baguette," "bottle of red wine," "bouquet of flowers"...

Semmelweis: This suggests that the vampire doesn't exclusively feed on blood as we thought.

Semmelweis: It apparently also dines on bread, wine, and flowers. Perhaps they consume pollen for energy.

"Razor": ...

Semmelweis: Just a little levity, "Razor." I am not suggesting that vampires are the nocturnal answer to bees.

Semmelweis: "Gruss an Aachen." I must say, this vampire has exquisite taste in flowers.

"Razor": Hm? What's this?

While Semmelweis is bent over the documents, "Razor" catches sight of something shiny in the corner.

"Razor": It looks like an Orbuculum ... uh-oh!

The Orbuculum flares up with a red glow.

"Razor": ...!

"Razor": Get down!

Woosh!

Dark red incantations shoot towards them.

A folded blade swings open. "Razor" swipes down on one spell after the other.

"Razor": Semmelweis, get out!

It's too late.

A shadow appears from behind Semmelweis.

???: ...

Semmelweis: ...!

A sharpness pierces her neck, pain radiates through her body as if tearing her in two.

The shadow covers Semmelweis entirely, crushing her beneath it.

Semmelweis: No—

Semmelweis: No!

Hotel

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis lurches up from the bed. She reaches out to place her hand on her chest, trying to calm the erratic beating of her heart.

She gasps for air, then puffs it out again as if trying to expel the memory.

Semmelweis: Was that a nightmare? Or perhaps a hallucination?

It's difficult to tell the difference, nothing feels real now.

She takes a deep breath and touches the wound on her neck.

The scars have nearly faded now, she traces her fingers over the twin puncture marks.

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis rises from her bed to look out from the window. The streets of Vienna are bustling with activity.

Carriages and trams roll side by side down the wide street, gentlemen engage in animated discussions at the cafe. It has an odd tranquility about it, like the calm before a storm.

It is a scene far removed from the mountains she remembers. She takes in three deep breaths.

A knock on the door interrupts her thoughts.

Emil: Captain, are you awake?

Semmelweis: What is it, Emil? Come in.

Emil: As per your instructions, I collected the latest newspapers from across Vienna.

Emil places the neatly sorted stack on the table.

Semmelweis leaves the view behind as she goes to pick up a newspaper.

Semmelweis: "The actress Isolde is about to hold an art exhibit in memory of her late brother, the famous artist Theophil's posthumous works will be displayed for the first time ..."

Semmelweis: Isolde ... I remember her. She was the star of the city's opera, before I left.

Emil: It seems she's still the hottest topic in Vienna today.

Emil: But the talk has shifted to this upcoming exhibit of hers.

Emil: "... The organizers hope to use it to provoke thought about and attention toward the Arcanists' plight."

Emil: Certainly it's one of the greatest issues of our time. But what good will an art exhibit be for that?

Emil: It won't change anything!

Emil points to the date on the newspaper.

Emil: But we are just in time. The exhibit is today ... Or even more precisely, in three hours.

Semmelweis: Of course, what could be more tantalizing to the Viennese public than a glimpse at the final works of a dead artist.

Semmelweis leafs through several more newspapers. Without exception, the front pages feature Isolde and Theophil's mourning portraits.

Emil: "Rising suicide rates," "museum thefts," "assassinations," and "major demonstrations" are all playing second fiddle to this event.

Semmelweis: I'm afraid it's hardly novel. There's something about when an artist takes his own life—that potent mix of tragedy and brilliance—No matter the era, it has always grabbed the headlines.

Semmelweis: All the more so that he was "the last male scion of an ancient noble house," the exact sort of gossip the Viennese gobble up. Politics and revolutions will have to wait their turn.

Emil: I guess I shouldn't expect any difference. This city has always found a way to distract itself with sensationalism, never mind that the Empire is falling apart at the seams.

Emil: They can't even put effort into addressing the "Arcanist" problem, which I'd say is the easiest to solve.

Emil: All their registration policies do is force law-abiding Arcanists to be weighed down by unwieldy bureaucracy.

Emil: Never mind that the lawless fanatics couldn't care less about the damned registration!

Emil: Mark my words, captain, these lunatics will drag the normal Arcanists down right along with them ... Uh, sorry, I didn't mean to ...

Emil catches himself, remembering perhaps too late that his supervisor too is an Arcanist. Embarrassed, he stops his tirade.

Semmelweis: If left unaddressed, these "Arcanist lunatics" are certain to turn many normal Arcanists into lunatics themselves. Unrest breeds further unrest, and crackdowns.

Semmelweis: However, I spare a little sympathy for the Empire, between the Bohemians, Croats, and Romanians, they're verging on total collapse. It is little wonder the Arcanist problem has been left to fester.

A wave of nationalism is sweeping through this era. With each side pulling apart, the tapestry of this ancient empire seems destined to be frayed and torn.

Noticing Emil's agitation, Semmelweis smiles disarmingly.

Semmelweis: Oh, never mind that, Emil. It's often unpleasant to deal with Arcanists. I admit, I am myself, not very fond of Arcanists.

Particularly when it comes to The Beyond.

Semmelweis: Please continue your report, Emil.

Emil: Arcanists ... Captain, that is to say, it relates to Arcanists.

Emil: I conducted a cursory investigation into the Arcanist refugee community here in Vienna and gathered more information about this so-called "Lorelei from the Rhine."

"Lorelei from the Rhine."

Even though she has been expecting it, Semmelweis catches her breath as she hears the name.

She instinctively recalls that letter—the one whose contents she has not disclosed to anyone in the Foundation.

Emil: Lorelei's reputation among the lower-class Arcanists is beyond what we had imagined.

Emil: Using her gift of "prophecy," she has united many Arcanist groups, so far preventing them from directly clashing with the Empire.

Semmelweis: "Prophecy?"

Emil: I prefer to call it "Arcanist nonsense."

Emil: It seems to me that only Arcanists could come up with and believe such superstition.

Semmelweis: But nonsense or otherwise the Arcanist refugees are convinced.

Emil: According to this prophecy of hers the world is a valley with a flowing river and we are colonies of ants living on either side of it.

Emil: In times past, we lived and died beside the river, enjoying its bounty, just as our ancestors did.

Emil: Today, however, the river is facing a cataclysm. The floodwaters will soon come rushing down to devour everything in their path.

Emil: And our valley will be no exception.

Emil: In her words, we are entirely helpless against this irreversible reckoning. All we can do is seek help to escape it.

Emil: But Lorelei claims to be the savior who will rescue everyone.

Semmelweis: ...!

Emil: It's all a bit cliche, isn't it? She may as well just call herself "Noah."

But to Semmelweis, this story meant something entirely different.

Semmelweis: Do you think this "flood" that Lorelei talks about may be the "Storm"?

Semmelweis: Just another doomsday prophecy, or is she really an oracle for the "Storm?"

Semmelweis: What is her goal in promoting this "prophecy?"

Countless questions begin to swirl in Semmelweis' mind.

Whether or not Lorelei's "prophecy" turns out to be true, she can no longer ignore the existence of the "Storm" in the Arcanist world.

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis: So, what about Lorelei? Did you find her?

Emil: Ah, unfortunately not, I haven't gotten any leads about Lorelei's whereabouts.

Emil: Except that she seems to have disappeared.

Semmelweis: That's strange. She should have returned to Vienna by now. Why else would she have me look for her here?

Emil: Captain? What are you talking about?

Semmelweis: ... Nothing. Please continue.

Emil: Simply put, after Lorelei disappeared, the Arcanist refugee community has splintered.

Emil: It's not yet risen to the level of the other crisis that the Empire is facing, but these out-of-control arcanists are threatening to cause significant problems.

Emil: According to the data, just this month, demonstrations and vicious incidents have been happening left and right. The Arcanist crime rate has doubled.

Emil: Some of the refugees have turned to the Manus Vindictae and have begun fighting what they call "the human powers that be."

Semmelweis: ...

Emil: Unfortunately, more than just some.

Emil hands a few selected articles over to Semmelweis.

Semmelweis: Riots, marches ...

Emil: They'll only continue to grow as long as the Arcanists lack a better voice to rally behind.

Semmelweis: Then we must find Lorelei as soon as we can.

Emil: We may find some more intel at the Vienna branch office.

Emil: They've investigated these groups in the past. I am sure they must have also taken the opportunity to investigate Lorelei.

Semmelweis: I see. Thank you for the information, Emil.

Semmelweis: I'll head over to the Vienna branch now.

Emil: Do you need me to go with you, Captain?

Semmelweis: No, I would prefer to go on my own.

Emil: Understood. Then the team and I will wait for your return.

Semmelweis turns to look out the window at the crowded street.

Semmelweis: Lorelei ... what on earth is she trying to do?

TO BE CONTINUED...

Second-Class Citizen

COL-600902

The way to the Foundation is choked with demonstrations.

Ring Road

Protestor I: Recognize Bohemia Now!

Protestor II: We demand representation from the Empire and from the Foundation! A tripartite empire! Long live Archduke Ferdinand!

Protestor I: Bohemians deserve equal recognition and rights!

There's no way forward except through the gathering crowd.

The converging demonstrators roil as a mass like a pot ready to boil.

Protestor III: Give it up! The Empire must not change!

Protestor IV: F***ing ungrateful Bohemians!

Semmelweis: It seems like there is no way through all these protests.

Semmelweis rubs her temples, and lets out an exasperated sigh.

The Foundation may not be the primary target of the protest, but they have already tightly sealed its entrance to avoid potential violence.

That was Karl's decision; she knows that instinctively.

Given the situation, it's doubtful they'd let her in. Even if she could find a way through.

Semmelweis: ... Karl is not a bad person—but no, he won't budge on this.

Normally, Semmelweis has no trouble with bureaucrats and their reservations. But, standing here looking at the results of their inaction, she mouths a few choice words.

Protestor III: Szarból, where are the guards? Where have all the guards gone?! Come on, round up these backwards yokels and send them back!

Protestor I: Brothers and sisters, did you hear what he just said?!

Protestor I: These Austrians are always so arrogant and dismissive of us!

Protestor II: That is why we must establish our own kingdom, a kingdom of the Bohemians!

Protestor III: Do you hear that?! The Empire should arrest and execute these traitors!

Protestor IV: Let's show them! Let's put the inferiors in their place!

The protestors quickly come to blows, engaging in a heated and bloody "exchange of ideas."

This scene calls to mind the image of two ant colonies fighting. Neither beautiful nor orderly; their actions driven solely by instinctive adrenaline.

Semmelweis: *sigh* Nothing interesting.

Semmelweis: There'll be no getting any information from the Foundation today. I'll have to find Lorelei another way.

Ignoring the chaos around her, she prepares to fall back to the hotel and make a new plan.

This fighting, wars of identity and nation, it's a small blip in history. Soon to be dust in the "Storm."

Semmelweis: Either way, I can't let myself be caught up in all this.

Semmelweis skirts the battle lines forming between the protestors, aiming for a narrow alley off of the main road.

It wouldn't be her first choice, but navigating the way back would be at best time-consuming, and at worst—dangerous.

Semmelweis: ... ?

A figure emerges from the group of Arcanist protestors.

Their face is hidden. But it seems that they intend to leave the scene via the same alley she is heading towards.

The figure seems to notice this as well.

???: You're from the Foundation ...? What bad luck! I don't have time for this right now!

The woman takes a few hurried steps forward and hurries into the alley ahead of Semmelweis.

Pausing a moment to think, Semmelweis pursues her into the alley.

Alley

The bright green of her dress stands out in the dreary alleyway. If she had been attempting to evade Semmelweis, she made a poor showing of it.

Kakania: I admit it, I'm not very good at hiding.

Kakania: But I can explain! I wasn't involved in this protest. You have to believe me!

Kakania: I can show you my Arcane Skill permit ... Shoot, where did I put it?

The woman in green reaches into her clothes but freezes in place.

Semmelweis: And you are ...?

Semmelweis glares at her, recalling any information she can about the green chatterbox before her.

Semmelweis: You are Kakania, yes? A known member of "The Circle?"

Kakania: You know me?

Semmelweis: Of course. Miss Kakania, I think you misunderstood.

Semmelweis: I'm from the Foundation, but any relation you have to the protests here is none of my concern.

Kakania: Oh! Good, good ... But I think I left my Arcane Skill permit at home. If you don't mind, I can take you to get it if you need to—

Semmelweis: —Nor am I here to check your Arcane Skill permit.

In a flash of movement, Kakania abruptly pulls aside a nearby curtain, revealing a mirror.

A brilliant white light flashes from it, that envelops Semmelweis completely.

Semmelweis attempts to react, but is too slow to escape the light.

Kakania: Apologies, miss.

Kakania: Under normal circumstances, I wouldn't do this, but I really have no time to spare explaining myself.

Kakania: Isolde's art exhibit is about to begin.

Kakania: Don't worry, I didn't use my full strength. You'll only be unconscious for half an hour, tops ...

Semmelweis: ...

Kakania: Well, that should do it.

Kakania snaps her fingers and the white light in the alley fades.

Kakania: ...!

As the light disperses. Semmelweis stands in place, entirely unaffected.

Semmelweis: I believe that did not go as you planned.

Semmelweis: Is your Arcane Skill just a matter of conjuring light? That's rather simple, wouldn't you agree?

Kakania: My Arcane Skill ... failed?

Kakania: It is just a little trick, but it should have been enough to get a glimpse into her mind—

But that trick depends on the person reflecting in the mirror.

Which she now realizes is empty, exactly where the woman before her should be.

Kakania: You ... you have no reflection at all!

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis also realizes this strange phenomenon.

Though in fact, Kakania's words are not entirely accurate.

There is a hazy reflection of a figure within. Though it could be easily mistaken for fog on the glass.

Semmelweis: That is most surprising ... Could it be an effect of the disease?

Kakania: How can this be?

Kakania: If only the timing were right, I would definitely give you a thorough examination.

Kakania: But, I have to make this quick.

Kakania's expression turns serious again, and the mirror emits another blast of dazzling light.

Kakania: Sorry!

This time the light takes some effect, Semmelweis is blinded for a moment from the bright flash.

Though it took all of Kakania's effort, the scene in the mirror at last begins to change.

Kakania: A burning attic, gray marble buildings, a melting sky ... what is all this?

Semmelweis: ...!

Joint Committee of SF

As Semmelweis opens her eyes, she notes the obvious; her surroundings have changed.

It is a hallucination, undoubtedly.

Naturally, she has plenty of experience with hallucinations. There is nothing special about this one —or at least, there shouldn't be.

Doctor: We meet again, Semmelweis.

Semmelweis: Indeed.

Semmelweis: With all due respect, I don't have time for idle chattering, Doctor.

Doctor: Really? You seem a bit nervous of me. But you needn't be so wary.

Doctor: I am you.

Bella: You may call me Bella. That's your real name, after all, not the codename the Foundation gave you.

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis: Whoever you are, I have a poor opinion of things that try to interfere with my mind.

Bella: Ah, so you think I'm a result of the Beyond Disease? Just another hallucination, a nightmare tugging at your strings.

Bella: But you've read the reports. So you know what this really is; you know that Miss Klara's Arcane Skill lets you glimpse your inner self.

Bella: You are not a fool, my dear. Do you still want to deny the truth right before your eyes?

Semmelweis: ...

Bella: It is an extraordinary ability, wouldn't you agree?

Bella: And for one so accustomed to deceiving everyone, even yourself. It proves dangerously effective.

Semmelweis is silent for a moment.

Semmelweis: I admit it, I have never seen anything like this before.

Bella: See, you've come so close. Now you must face your truth.

Bella: So, don't try to pull that "Foundation" nonsense on me again. You and I know very well that it's nothing more than a disguise to you.

Bella: If you are so loyal to the Foundation, tell me why you did not tell them what you know about Lorelei?

Semmelweis: ... The Foundation is simply the best way for me to handle things right now.

Bella: Loyalty with reservations is not true loyalty.

Bella: It's mutual exploitation.

Bella: Let's be honest with ourselves, shall we? You don't trust the Foundation, Semmelweis.

Bella: Everything you have done has been for yourself.

Bella: Joining the Foundation was just a chance to be closer to the arcanum.

Bella: You became a Field Agent all in the hope that you'd find a cure.

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis: What of it?

Semmelweis: Since the start, the Foundation has offered me the best way for me to accomplish my goals.

Semmelweis: That's never been in dispute.

Bella: I'm just happy to hear you finally say what you truly believe.

Bella: You aren't so noble. You're just another person running from death, trying to change your fate.

Bella: It's in your nature.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Professional Ethics

COL-600903

Kakania's Clinic

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis: Where am I?

Semmelweis puts her hand on her head and sits up from the couch.

Kakania: You're finally awake!

Semmelweis subconsciously surveys the room's decor.

Semmelweis: Strange, I remember, just now ...

The room is quiet.

It has been a long time since Semmelweis has enjoyed such silence.

Kakania: This is my psychiatry clinic.

Semmelweis: A psychiatrist! I see, well you'll forgive me if I mistook it for a warehouse.

Semmelweis: Don't get me wrong, I greatly respect psychiatrists. Of course, I do find them a bit nosy, always trying to dig their way into your private matters.

Kakania: I'm very sorry.

Semmelweis: Whatever for?

Kakania: Though it was rather blurry, I didn't see any hint of hostility from you in the mirror.

Kakania: It was wrong of me to attack you, I acted rashly.

The green parrot lowers her head with an awkward expression.

Semmelweis: You've been making a bad habit of dazzling others in the streets, Dr. Kakania.

Semmelweis: I am now the second victim of your particular brand of light-based assaults.

Kakania: Oh! So you're a friend of Marcus too?

Kakania: I apologize, but it is in my nature to pry. What exactly did you see while you were under my Arcane Skill?

Semmelweis: Why do you ask?

Kakania: Everyone sees different things in the mirror, it reflects one's own truth, their innermost turmoil and desires.

Kakania: Your reflection though was hazy and the fragments it formed were vague. It was impossible to extract any useful information.

Semmelweis: My own truth ...

Semmelweis: No, there was nothing, just some familiar hallucinations I've long grown accustomed to, that's all.

Kakania: Of course, you aren't my patient, and I have no intention of prying into your privacy. But I ask such questions as a matter of professional ethics.

Semmelweis: Professional ethics?

Kakania: If our consultation here is anything to go by, you may be dealing with a very serious mental illness.

Kakania: As a psychiatrist, I cannot stand idly by. Whether you are my patient or not, I feel I must speak with you frankly.

Semmelweis: I've heard that line many times before.

Semmelweis: Though far more often it concerns my physical illnesses, I confess this is the first time I've heard that I am sick in the head as well.

Kakania: To put it simply, I have observed that your spirit is undergoing drastic changes. And that these intense changes have triggered significant mental distress.

Semmelweis: Drastic spiritual changes?

Kakania: Yes. I'm sure you are familiar with the saying: "Mankind is inclined to reason, Arcanists are inclined to sensitivity."

Kakania: Emotions are the heart of spirituality. When our perspectives change, those with keen emotions, especially Arcanists, exhibit more obvious symptoms.

Kakania: Insomnia, nightmares, hallucinations, schizophrenia—even the disappearance of one's reflection. I suspect these are all possible symptoms of spiritual changes in an Arcanist.

Semmelweis: "Spiritual changes?" A most interesting way to put it.

Kakania: The issue of spiritual changes remains a challenge in the medical field. I'm sorry to say my understanding is limited too.

Kakania: But according to our extant medical knowledge, these effects seem to stem from drastic changes related to arcanum and the side effects they cause ...

Mid-sentence, Kakania suddenly remembers something and abruptly stands up.

Kakania: Ah ...!!! Oh no!

Semmelweis: What is it?

Kakania: Oh, look at the time—the exhibit! I'm going to be late!

Semmelweis: Isolde's art exhibit? It's just another in a long line of Vienna's high-profile social gatherings.

Semmelweis: Though, apparently this one intends to promote the plight of the Arcanists across the Empire.

Semmelweis: It is without a doubt one of the greatest issues of our time.

Kakania: Miss Semmelweis, I am happy to hear that you are so sympathetic to the theme of this exhibit. It seems many Viennese do not care about the organizer's ideals; they come only to gawk at the art.

Semmelweis: Naturally I'm sympathetic, it's an urgent and serious topic.

Semmelweis: I have always believed that the Foundation needs to listen to the experiences and opinions of Arcanists like you. People with outside perspectives, that can speak for those beyond the Foundation's sometimes narrow mindset.

Kakania: I am happy to know that the Foundation has such dedicated young people like you and Ms. Marcus!

The eloquent girl in green comes to an apparent realization. She pauses and stares intently at Semmelweis from behind her bright eyes.

Kakania: Oh! You know, I think you may just be interested in this exhibit too. After all, you are a friend of Ms. Marcus—

Kakania: A pity I only gave her two invitations. I think you are most deserving of one.

Kakania: A major oversight on the organizer's part! Let me see if there are any extra invitations ...

Semmelweis: Thank you for your diagnosis and the invitation, Dr. Kakania.

Semmelweis stands up from the sofa, her trajectory already set for the door.

Semmelweis: But I'm afraid I've never received any sort of aesthetic education. I have no proper appreciation for art.

Semmelweis: Inviting me to such an exhibit, you may as well bring a toad to the opera.

Semmelweis: At any rate, I'm on an urgent mission from the Foundation, which leaves me with even no such time to spare.

Kakania: —Not in this envelope, nor this one either.

Kakania pays no mind to her refusal. She simply carries on rummaging through the scattered files and cabinets.

Kakania: Oh no, it seems all the blank invitations have already been given out.

Kakania taps her head ruefully.

Kakania: Only Miss Valentina and Miss Lorelei's invitations are left, and they have their names on them ... I should have asked Heinrich to prepare a few more.

Semmelweis: ...!

Semmelweis: Wait, did you just say Lorelei?

Kakania: Hm? So you know Miss Lorelei, too?

Kakania: I mean Miss Lorelei is a famous social activist and singer in Vienna. I suppose it only makes sense that you would have heard of her.

Kakania: You know, Miss Lorelei has always been so dedicated to promoting equality between mankind and Arcanists. She is well-respected by just about everyone.

Kakania: That's why I specially invited Miss Lorelei and Miss Valentina to the exhibit. And, I admit, because I've always wanted to meet them.

Kakania: Unfortunately, Miss Lorelei left Vienna not long ago. No one knows where she is now.

Semmelweis' fingertips tremble slightly, but she quickly hides her excitement.

Semmelweis: Oh? That's a pity, I was thinking that if I had the chance, I should like to pay her a visit.

Semmelweis: But by the sounds of it, I seem to have missed my chance.

Kakania: Not entirely! I'm not sure where she is now, but I think Miss Valentina must know.

Semmelweis: Miss Valentina?

Kakania: She's another social activist and a very good friend of Lorelei.

Kakania: She runs a small bar near the river port. Maybe you can try your luck there.

Kakania: If you need to speak with her, I can give you more detailed directions.

At this, Kakania picks up a parrot feather from a nearby table and hands it to Semmelweis.

Kakania: There's a vendor I know. Just give him this feather and he'll help you find Miss Valentina!

Kakania: But I apologize. I'm afraid I can't go with you myself, Miss Semmelweis.

Kakania: I am expected at the exhibit's opening ritual. As a member of "The Circle," I have to be in attendance.

Semmelweis: I understand entirely, Doctor.

Semmelweis: I don't know much about art, but I think I understand how important this showcase of Mr. Theophil's posthumous works must be to you.

Semmelweis steadies her still trembling hand as she reaches for the feather.

Semmelweis: Without further ado, I must take my leave, doctor.

Semmelweis puts the feather in her pocket and nods to Kakania.

Kakania: Good luck, Miss Semmelweis!

TO BE CONTINUED...

Saluting Aachen, Part 1

COL-600904

Vendor: So you're looking to find Miss Valentina?

Semmelweis: That's right.

Vendor: Follow me, don't get lost.

Vendor: The weather looks bad. I think it's going to rain. We should hurry.

Vendor: People around here are quite wary of the Foundation. So I suggest you don't do anything out of line.

Semmelweis: Don't worry, I'm just here following some leads, I don't intend to cause any issues.

Semmelweis: The atmosphere feels different here than it used to.

Vendor: You're right—there are many more Arcanists here now. Too many.

Semmelweis: No, I meant something else, has anything else changed here? For the better?

Vendor: Better? There is no such thing as "better" in this world. Not in our world anyway, miss.

Vendor: But there is one thing worth mentioning.

Vendor: I've heard that Miss Lorelei found a way to survive the "flood."

Semmelweis: "The river is in unprecedented chaos ... the flood will come rushing down and devour everything in its path ..."

Vendor: Oh? You've heard Miss Lorelei's prophecy too?

Semmelweis: I only know a bit. I'd like to know more.

Vendor: Miss Lorelei believes that there is a "rock" not far from us. That this "rock" will be able to protect us against the flood.

Semmelweis: A "rock"? Could it be—

Vendor: A lot of folks are convinced that she'll lead them to this "sanctuary" of hers, but me, personally, I think it's better to trust Miss Valentina and her friends.

Semmelweis: Friends?

Vendor: Yeah, she's got some friends from the United States. People say they've found a way to survive the "flood."

Vendor: What was it she called them? ... "Manus Vindictae?"

Semmelweis: ...!

Vendor: I'm more interested in their theory! They made some big promises too, but it still seemed more realistic. Besides, they said they'll pay us to march in the streets for them!

Semmelweis: A "rock" and "Manus Vindictae"...

Semmelweis: I'm curious about Valentina. I heard both her and Lorelei are close friends.

Vendor: That's right. She and Lorelei are the best of friends. I must say, it was the right decision for you to come looking for her.

Vendor: Miss Lorelei hasn't been seen in Vienna for a long time. But if anyone knows where to find her, it'll be Valentina.

Vendor: We're here.

Vendor: Wait a bit. I'll go tell Valentina you've arrived.

The bar was small, lacking a sign or even a window, only a small tightly shut doorway.

Several burly thugs stand near the entrance, each watching Semmelweis warily.

Each of them has a bulge on their hips. Clearly not wands, but firearms.

The vendor approaches the thugs and whispers a few words to the apparent leader.

The thug nods. Looking at Semmelweis, he steps aside motion to the doorway.

Thug: Go on in. Miss Valentina will be waiting for you inside.

Semmelweis nods and looks at the vendor.

Semmelweis: Thank you for your help. And best of luck with the "flood."

Vendor: Oh, thank you miss, you too!

The thug makes a sideways glance at Semmelweis as she passes through.

Thug: I'm warning you, you government lackey, don't try to be clever.

Valentina's Bar

It is just as small as it had appeared from the outside.

The room is dark save for a few dim lights.

Her eyes have not yet adjusted when she hears the clicking of the lock behind her.

And the dim outline of a person with her back turned behind the bar.

???: I've waited a long time for you to find your way here, Semmelweis.

As the figure emerges into the dim light, Semmelweis' heart begins to pound with a familiar violence.

It becomes a pulse that shoots up her vagus nerve, to her jaw, and creeps over her tongue.

A sweet, metallic taste spreads from the tip of her tongue and fills the space between her incisors and canines.

"Kill her."

A voice whispers seductively in Semmelweis' ear.

It is the very same voice that comes to her in her hallucinations, and yet her instincts agree.

"Kill her."

These inward whispers drown out all other sound in Semmelweis' ears.

???: Let me guess what you're thinking right now.

???: "Kill her." Am I right?

???: Greetings, Semmelweis ...

As her eyes at last adjust and make out the features of the figure's face, she recognizes it for what it is.

A face she cannot forget. The faint, elusive smile that haunts her nightmares.

Semmelweis: ... YOU VAMPIRE!

Semmelweis: How dare you show your face to me!

Semmelweis: I'll tear you apart! I'll slit your throat! I'll—

The Beyond stands in front of her, a "vampire," and the very creature responsible for her condition.

Passion clouds her vision and, driven by instinct, she charges at the figure.

???: "Vampire?" What a vulgar word.

Seeing Semmelweis' charging towards her, the vampire chuckles softly, the dark red glow of an Arcane Skill flickering in her hand.

???: A dose of pain should calm you down.

Semmelweis: Wait, I just ...

Thoughts flash through her mind veering toward a gruesome memory.

The madness in her eyes is replaced by clarity and determination.

And to her astonishment, it matched a look of surprise in the vampire's own eyes.

???: So, you managed to control yourself.

Semmelweis stops. She gasps and sinks to her knees before the vampire.

Semmelweis: You ... you ... damn ... monster.

???: You're the first Arcanist I've seen who can control themselves in the throes of instinct.

???: You know, you're beginning to surprise me, my little changeling.

???: You ought to be grateful. At the very least that you're still alive.

The vampire looked down at Semmelweis with a look of keen interest.

Semmelweis: I can't let the trail go cold here.

Semmelweis: So, you're the one they call Valentina.

Semmelweis pressed her hand to her chest and stood up.

Valentina: I rarely see such outstanding willpower in your short-lived kind ... I'm beginning to believe you might even survive your transformation.

Valentina: Vampires, bloodfiends, shadowless spirits—Arcanists have many names for us. Call me whatever you like.

Valentina: Yet, your memory is quite correct. I am the Beyond who bit and infected you.

Semmelweis: You talk like you already know me.

Valentina: Because I do, pet. I took notice of you back when you first began working for the Foundation in Vienna. Besides, I rarely forget such an interesting dish.

Valentina: Not to mention that one gains some unique tricks over a long lifespan.

Valentina: In any case, once I had gathered the necessary information, all I needed to do was leave a few breadcrumbs, and you would take care of rescuing Lorelei for me.

Valentina: As my present enemies are other Manus Vindictae factions, it was difficult for me to do anything. So, in this regard, you have already proved useful.

Semmelweis: So, you were the one who left that note?

Valentina shakes her head.

Valentina: This time, you're wrong. I didn't leave the note. I only told Lorelei about it, she was the one who insisted on helping you.

Valentina: The mirror was a gift from Lorelei, too.

Valentina: You'll have to ask Lorelei about that ... but I can already imagine her answer.

Valentina: As far as she's concerned, she just wanted to help you.

Valentina: Lorelei is, of all you very short-lived creatures, among the best I've ever known. As such, I tend to bend to her whims, even when they threaten to derail my plans.

Semmelweis: It sounds like you know exactly where Lorelei is right now.

Valentina: Of course! After all, that's why you're here.

Valentina: But ... before all that, I have a proposal. Would you like to hear it?

Valentina: I have the solution to all the problems you're facing now. We can complete the transformation and you'll become a full Infected.

Semmelweis: Transformation ... is that what you call it? It feels rather more like falling apart.

Valentina: You don't really know what is happening to your own body now.

Valentina: How much do you know about the Infected?

Semmelweis: Arcanists who have been infected by the Beyond suffer from the Beyond Disease. It destroys us from the inside out.

Semmelweis: Its mortality rate is well over 93%, and of those few that survive, they remain "Infected." Even if they survive, most go on to develop severe mental illnesses.

Valentina: I see, it sounds like the Foundation has hidden a great deal from you.

Semmelweis: You're not very subtle, for a vampire. I'd make your next choice of words carefully.

Valentina: "Anyone bitten by a vampire becomes a new vampire" that's how the legends go, don't they? The essence of the Beyond Disease is "a series of symptoms caused by the sudden increase of Arcanist blood."

Valentina: The blood of the Beyond is rapidly re-forming you in both mind and body. And it is true indeed that few can withstand the change.

Valentina: But it is far from a disease, it is only a process. Your body is becoming like mine.

Semmelweis: What you're saying can't possibly be true.

Semmelweis: The bloodlines of mankind and Arcanists are both predestined and unchangeable. That much is common knowledge.

Semmelweis: Do you really think you can tempt me with lies and false promises?

Valentina: I wouldn't lie about this, Semmelweis.

Valentina: Restraint is something our kind have long had to master.

Valentina: I can see the doubt in your eyes. An ill-timed, easily-disproved lie would render my work fruitless.

Valentina: Consider this, an infected Arcanist becomes more and more similar to the Beyond that infected her.

Valentina: Just think, without changing their bloodline, how could such a transformation happen?

Valentina: Besides living on blood, vampires' most well-known traits are that we fear sunlight, cast no shadow, and cannot be seen in mirrors.

Semmelweis: No shadow ...

Valentina: If my timing is correct, your shadow has all but disappeared by now.

Semmelweis: ...

Valentina: Shall I assume my timing is correct then?

Valentina: Now just imagine someone extracting your blood and bones by force, reshaping them, and then shoving them back into your body. When you consider the nature of the change, it is little wonder we are so rare.

Semmelweis: I have a question.

Semmelweis: I want to know ... will this "transformation" impact my Arcane Skill?

Valentina: Hm?

Valentina seemed momentarily taken aback by Semmelweis' unexpected question.

Semmelweis: To put it frankly, after I become an Infected, will I be able to use Arcane Skills?

Valentina: ...

Valentina: Heh ... I suppose I never thought I would need to be asked.

Semmelweis: Please, the answer to this question is very important to me.

Semmelweis: I don't have any incantation skills of my own. For now I can only use Arcane Skills developed by human technology.

Semmelweis: If what you say is true and my bloodline has changed, then it would stand to reason that I might now be able to—

Semmelweis: There would be no better way to prove your claim.

Valentina: Fascinating. What a truly interesting individual you are.

Valentina: I made the right choice in you, I think. Whether or not you'd have chosen it for yourself.

Valentina: Let us see if we can answer your question. Perhaps then, you might consider my offer.

Valentina walks to Semmelweis' side, reaching out to take her hand.

Valentina: Recite the incantation with me.

Semmelweis: ...

Valentina: Don't be nervous. This is only a simple incantation.

Semmelweis & Valentina: Scarlatum!

Nothing happens.

Semmelweis: What did I do wrong? Was it my intonation?

Valentina: There is still so much human in you, even as a mixed blood.

Valentina: You still rely too much on reason. You are saying the words like a formula, not an incantation.

Valentina: The language we use is only a tool. What brings forth an Arcane Skill is the spiritual power within.

Valentina: But perhaps I should have given you more instruction.

Semmelweis: Instruction ...?

TO BE CONTINUED...

Saluting Aachen, Part 2

COL-600905

Valentina: These clothes fit you much better than that old Foundation uniform.

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis: Your taste in fashion is nearly as old as you are.

Semmelweis: I don't think it's going to do anything.

Semmelweis: If a change of clothes was all that was needed, I would have been able to use an Arcane Skill a long time ago.

Valentina: It will help.

Valentina: You're used to failure. So, it's important to give yourself hints of success some other way.

Semmelweis: I sincerely doubt this will work. But, if you insist, I'll try it again.

Semmelweis: One last time.

Semmelweis: Scarlatum!

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis: I failed.

Valentina: No, not yet.

Semmelweis: ...!

Semmelweis: What ...?

Valentina: Congratulations, Semmelweis. You just used an Arcane Skill.

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis focus is elsewhere.

She stares blankly at the dot of light before her, unsure if she can believe her own eyes.

In this moment, all that she can see is that light.

Had she really so easily accomplished this decades-long dream?

Valentina: How does it feel to use an Arcane Skill?

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis: .....

Semmelweis closes her eyes. As she reopens them, she pushes her excitement deep down below the surface.

Semmelweis: ... Your theory was correct.

Semmelweis: If this Disease were only an illness, I would not have gained the ability to use an Arcane Skill.

Valentina: Huh? I thought you would be a little happier, frankly.

Semmelweis: I don't have time to waste on unimportant emotions. There are more important goals.

Valentina: You mean like staying alive?

Semmelweis: Right. All of this will be fruitless if I don't live to use it.

Valentina: I like this simple and direct desire of yours. It's very convincing.

Valentina: Like you, I too think "staying alive" is a fitting goal. Perhaps the most fitting of all.

Valentina: Though I do not fear death, so much as the idea of missing out on life and all its interests. Death to me seems quite boring.

Valentina: Sadly, it is on that account that I felt obligated to join with Manus VIndictae.

Semmelweis: If you just want to make it through the "Storm," you don't need to join Manus Vindictae. The Foundation also has ways of surviving the "Storm."

Valentina: Oh, don't be stupid, Semmelweis.

Valentina: A boring, stuffy place like that is a place of endless torment for a long-lived species such as ourselves.

Valentina: Besides, I promised Lorelei that I'd help her take care of the Arcanist refugees.

Valentina: Your Foundation would never be able to accommodate so many "useless" Arcanists. Joining Manus Vindictae is my only choice.

Semmelweis: I confess, if I were you, I might make the same choice.

Valentina: So, let me make you an offer.

Valentina: I'll help you survive the transformation and become a true Infected.

Valentina: But in return, I need you to join us and become my strength.

Semmelweis: Join you?

Semmelweis: You want me, a captain of the Foundation's Field Agent Squad, to join Manus Vindictae? You can't mean that.

Valentina: Of course I do! Just to snatch one of their captains would be an achievement in itself to savor, but there's more to it than that.

Valentina: As it was for me, the Manus Vindictae are your best option.

Valentina: When it comes down to it, the Foundation is just a humanist group. And you are no longer a half-blood Arcanist who can't use any Arcane Skill. Now, among the Manus Vindictae, you would be valued.

Valentina: I can help you complete the transformation and in time, teach you Arcane Skills unique to vampires.

Valentina: Let us work together and secure a place in Manus Vindictae.

Valentina: What do you say? Are my terms acceptable?

Semmelweis: I admit, I find your offer quite tempting.

Semmelweis: But unfortunately, I cannot accept.

Valentina: Why? You aren't still holding a grudge because I infected you?

Semmelweis: No, it isn't that.

Semmelweis: The past is the past. I wouldn't let that affect my judgment.

Semmelweis: No, I'm refusing you because I know you have not told me the whole truth.

Semmelweis: The value I am demonstrating now is not worth the price you'd pay for me to join. You have another motive.

Valentina: I am well aware of your abilities. As a vampire having a capable "kindred spirit" on my side would be invaluable.

Valentina: And even if you're not on Lorelei's level, you remain one of the most interesting Arcanists I've ever encountered.

Valentina: And I tend to favor interesting people.

Semmelweis: Not good enough.

Valentina: Well, I think it is.

Semmelweis: Of course, you're the one making the judgment. I can't fault your reasoning.

Valentina shrugs her shoulders, and says no more.

Semmelweis: I have another question, is it true what Lorelei said about being able to cure me?

Valentina: You can't help but look at all the angles, can't you? Well, I've already agreed not to stand in your way if you go looking for her.

Valentina: She does have the means to help you, albeit in a different way.

Valentina: But I still recommend my plan, it gives you the best chance of survival. Besides, it's much more fun than Lorelei's way.

Semmelweis: I'll consider it, Miss Valentina.

Valentina: As you wish. She's currently somewhere in the Leopoldstadt—

boom

Valentina's words are cut off by the sudden sound of gunfire.

Semmelweis: ...?!

The gunfire outside the room grows more intense.

Valentina: Is it the Imperial police? No, the police wouldn't fire so rashly.

Valentina: Schwab, what's going on out there?

Thug: Who are you? Stop! Don't get any closer—ah!

There is a gunshot and a pained grunt.

Scoundrel: Shoot, damn it!

There is short, intense exchange of fire.

Then an eerie silence.

Semmelweis turns to the door.

There is a pool of liquid forming from outside. In the dim light it appears crimson red.

The door clatters from a heavy blow, the lock barely holding on.

The crash comes again, and again, until the would-be intruders seem to give up.

Semmelweis: What the hell was that?

Valentina: Heh, that was certainly something wasn't it? I've been needing a bit of fun—

Valentina: The police, no? Military, doubtful? A counterintelligence agency? No, no, and no.

Valentina: Perhaps someone is acting out of schedule ...

Valentina walks toward a table in the bar. Forcefully flipping it over to reveal a hidden passage beneath it.

She opens the passage and gestures to Semmelweis.

Valentina: Well, don't just stand there!

Just then, a voice outside cries out.

Soldier: Captain! Bring the Schwarzlose!

Valentina: "Schwarzlose?" I wonder what that could be? Sounds like a person's name.

Semmelweis: Schwarzlose ...

Semmelweis: S**t! That's a Schwarzlose heavy machine gun! They must be the Imperial Army.

Semmelweis: But would they really use a heavy weapon like that in the city? Have they gone mad?!

A resolute order bellows out from beyond the door.

Soldier: Fire! Fire! Fire!

There is a brief moment of silence before the room explodes into rattling eruptions of sound and fury. Punching through the walls of the building as if it were paper.

There is an unexplainable look of realization in Valentina's eyes.

But she doesn't speak. Instead, she pulls Semmelweis over and pushes her into the hidden passage.

The next moments slow to a near frozen crawl.

Each detail etched in her mind with crystal clarity.

The trajectory of each bullet as they cut through the air.

Valentina's mouth as it hangs open—like she is about to say something.

The light that flashes in her eyes and the corners of her mouth as they turn up into a peculiar smile.

Then the bullet that emerges from her skull.

Semmelweis: Valentina!

She yells vainly already knowing there is no trace of life left in the body before her.

The long-lived vampire lies slain, with that strange smile still wrenched on her lips.

Semmelweis: You d**med thing. You didn't even finish telling me where to find Lorelei!

Soldier: Keep firing, don't stop! Make sure everyone inside is dead!

The gunfire outside the walls grows more intense.

Before she enters the tunnel, she notices a crack in the bricks and the sky outside.

Semmelweis: Is that ... oil paint?

Streaks of paint fill the sky like a work of Van Gogh. Its somber colors seem ready to drip from the dome of the heavens at any moment.

Almost simultaneously, the Foundation communication device she is carrying starts to ring.

Communicator: Attention all units, the Timekeeper has issued a "Storm" warning.

Communicator: The "Storm" will arrive in 24 hours.

Communicator: All personnel must make their way to the nearest station and return to headquarters immediately.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Fate in the Mirror

COL-600906

Vienna Before the "Storm"

Hysterical shouts pierce above the din of the mad crowd in the streets, punctuated by shattering glass, the sporadic hammering sound of gunfire.

People infected by the Storm Syndrome flood the streets in a hysterical mass. Having lost all sense of reason.

Blood and paint mix together forming a nightmarish masterpiece. The colors hang high in the sky like a mural on the dome of the world.

Semmelweis reaches the street.

In her hand is a note that she found in the pocket of her clothes. On it is Lorelei's location.

At some point—perhaps the very beginning—Valentina had put the note in the pocket of her outfit.

Whatever her true intentions were, they died with her in that hail of gunfire.

Communicator: Beep beep!

Madam Lindsay: Semmelweis, the Timekeeper has issued a 24 hour "Storm" warning.

Madam Lindsay: The closest evacuation point to you is Vienna station. Complete all necessary follow-up procedures and evacuate immediately.

Semmelweis: Understood. Thank you, Madam Lindsay.

Madam Lindsay: It's still somewhat premature, but I have been instructed to inform you of the good news.

Madam Lindsay: The LSCC has finished their analysis of your blood. They believe they will be able to make an inhibiting serum soon.

Madam Lindsay: You know what to do, right?

Madam Lindsay: There isn't any time left to waste. Not for the Foundation, not for yourself either.

Semmelweis: Thank you, Madam Lindsay.

Her only response is the tell-tale fizzle that ends their communication.

Semmelweis: ...

Bella: The Storm Syndrome this time is so much more fun than the previous ones, wouldn't you agree?

Bella appears at Semmelweis' side, she seems so much more real than ever before.

Semmelweis: I wish I could share your perspective. However, uninvited hallucinations are not included in the symptoms of the Storm Syndrome this time.

Bella: If only it were that, no, you can see me precisely because the Beyond's bloodline is already altering your mind.

Bella: It is a change that brings tearing and reorganization. And it seems I am one such part that is being torn out.

Bella: And as a part of you, I believe I have the right to object to your behavior.

Semmelweis: What a shame, the Foundation's laws don't provide for the rights of hallucinations.

Semmelweis: Though as much as I am loath to hear you, I can't stop you from talking.

Bella: I know what you're planning. You want to go find Lorelei and get the means to finish the transformation from her.

Bella: You can't bear the thought that of losing what you've been given. That's always the appeal of weapons, and the danger. Once given, how much harder are they to give up?

Bella: And our new found Arcane Skill is no exception to that rule.

Bella: So, you will do whatever you can to not give up your life nor the Arcane Skill we've wanted for so long. How greedy.

Semmelweis: Valentina is dead. I have no other choice.

Bella: No. The "Storm" is coming. And the Foundation will be monitoring your every move as we speak.

Bella: They will find out if you go looking for Lorelei. Even so, will you still insist on searching for her?

Bella: You don't even know if she really has a cure for you. How easily you fall for the honeyed words of that vampire.

Bella: This could be another of her traps.

Semmelweis: There's still enough time for me to find Lorelei and get back—

Bella: The Foundation will view this as a betrayal, Semmelweis.

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis: I have made many choices, some good and some bad. But without exception, everything I have done ...

Semmelweis: Has been to take control of my fate.

Semmelweis: I'm aware that I am not special. With neither the intuitive rationality of humanity, nor the Arcanist's power over arcanum.

Semmelweis: I'm stuck somewhere in the middle.

Semmelweis: The Foundation, Manus Vindictae, Valentina, none of them saw me as valuable, I am only ever a means to an end.

Semmelweis: I will not place my fate in anyone's hands but my own.

Bella: ...

Bella: It seems you've made up your mind.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Waves and Notes

COL-600907

The Storm Syndrome spreads in a slow roll through the city. As people and buildings alike are transformed into a strange and colorful new image.

Soldier: What do we do? There are too many people, I can't tell who the rioters are!

Soldier: Just kill everyone. Better than missing a single one of them.

The soldier takes the pistol from his hip, sticks it in his mouth, and pulls the trigger.

In his deranged mind everyone appeared to begin with himself.

Gendarme I: Damn! Are all these people out of their damned minds?

Gendarme II: My sword ... why is my sword in your leg?

Gendarme I: Stop thinking about your sword! We need to secure the Emperor's wealth!

Gendarme I: Our orders were to shoot anyone who gets in the way of our search.

Gendarme I: Wait, my carbine is stuck in my back. Help me get it off, otherwise I can't shoot!

Even though they are being eroded by the Storm Syndrome, the gendarmes are still faithfully trying to carry out their orders.

Semmelweis: According to the address Valentina gave me, this should be where Lorelei is hiding.

Bella: But she didn't specify a door number.

Semmelweis: Damn it, I don't have time to ask around.

Bella: Hurry, Semmelweis. It won't be long before Madam Lindsay realizes you're off schedule.

Semmelweis: I don't need you to remind me.

Bella: Naturally. We are the same person ...

Bella: Wait, did you hear something?

Semmelweis: Is that ... singing?

Like that echo in the valley, the unforgettable voice reaches Semmelweis' ears, marred by the staccato rhythm of distant gunfire.

She takes a moment to reassure herself.

Semmelweis: Could this still be a hallucination? No. No, it's—

The air is cool, the dusk, it deepens,

And gently flows the Rhine,

The mountain's summit sparkles bright,

In the evening's golden light.

The song is crisp and calming, like the spray of waves stirred up on a reef.

Semmelweis: ...!

Bella: Looks like you found her.

The singer has the very same voice and hauntingly familiar melody.

???: ...

Like a mythical mermaid, a girl rests atop the towering reef, and the crowd beneath her crawls up to her like the doomed sailors of legend.

Semmelweis: Are they ... calming down?

The brawling crowd slows and then in a wave lower to the ground until they have all fallen into a slumber.

Gendarme I: Why was I shooting in the first place?

Gendarme II: It was the Emperor's order. But now, I think the Emperor would like us to take a nap.

The two gendarmes join the ranks of the sleepers.

Semmelweis: Incredible ... she calmed everyone with only a song, just like the sirens in the legends.

Noticing Semmelweis' arrival, the girl stops singing.

Semmelweis: I've never seen such an Arcane Skill.

???: ...

???: We meet again, little musical note. I am so pleased to see you.

Semmelweis: I don't think we've met before, Lorelei.

Lorelei: I heard your echo from far away, my dear.

Semmelweis: ...

Lorelei: Lorelei! Yes, you may call me that, I like that name.

Lorelei: It's like a nice little word with a simple melody.

Lorelei: I'm so glad you enjoyed my song.

Semmelweis: I'm sure it is a great name, one shared with the siren of legend.

Lorelei: I'm happy we could meet in person. I was wondering when you would get here.

Semmelweis: Me? Why?

Lorelei: Because the "flood" is coming, of course.

Lorelei: My dear, I want to ask you something.

Lorelei: The "Flood" is a trial we all must face. Only those who pass may see the world after it.

Lorelei: That's what Manus Vindictae says.

Lorelei: But is that really true?

Lorelei: Everyone should have the right to choose to cross through the "Flood."

Semmelweis: That's not realistic. Neither the Foundation nor Manus Vindictae can take everyone safely to the next era unconditionally.

Semmelweis: In any case, this has nothing to do with why I came here.

Semmelweis: Lorelei, you wrote in your letter that you have some way to help me through my "transformation." That's why I have come.

Semmelweis: I believe that the song you left in my mind was meant to guide me to you.

Lorelei: You heard my song! I do hope you liked it, my dear!

Semmelweis: Of course, I don't expect you to help me with no strings attached—

Lorelei: Ah, hold on a moment.

Semmelweis: What is it?

Lorelei raises a hand to shush Semmelweis.

Lorelei: Mama is calling me.

She raises the conch she is carrying and holds it to her ear.

Lorelei: I heard the sound of splashing. Did you hear it too, mama?

Lorelei: A black stallion, draped in white, wades through the "Flood."

Lorelei: What should I do, papa? I can hear so many echoes, which one should I respond to?

Lorelei: I know what I need to do, mama!

Semmelweis: ...

Lorelei: Sorry, my little musical note ... Where were we?

Lorelei: Oh, you said something I don't understand, why should my help be conditional?

Lorelei: Every note is necessary to hold the melody. If one falls so do the rest.

Lorelei: So, it's only natural that we help each other.

Semmelweis: ...

Bella: You must be regretting your choices right now, Semmelweis.

Bella: You see, this is why I tried to stop you. You simply cannot understand what an Arcanist is thinking. You have no idea what she wants.

Bella: Arcanists are mad, just as mankind are deceitful.

Bella: But comparing madness to deceit, one is far more reliable. You can trust the liar to lie in their interest, but the mad—

Semmelweis: Shut up.

Semmelweis: Sorry, I wasn't talking to you, Lorelei.

Lorelei: That was not very kind of you, little musical note.

Semmelweis: I apologize, I did not intend any offense.

Lorelei: It was an echo of your dreams, wasn't it?

Semmelweis: ...!

Lorelei: Pretty little musical note like you often have close companions. How much closer than should be the ones within you?

Lorelei: So, why are you being so rude to yourself, my dear? Those echoes are a part of you. You ought to learn to embrace them.

Lorelei: I also see my mama and papa in dreams. I think it is quite normal really, dear.

Bella: Living in harmony with your madness, even as your consciousness is being torn out of you? She has no idea what she's saying.

Bella: You found this Arcanist by defying the Foundation's orders. Do you earnestly think this was worth the risk?

Semmelweis shakes away Bella's disruptions.

Semmelweis: Lorelei, I have secured a spot to help one person escape the "Storm."

Semmelweis: If would tell me how to complete the transformation, I can arrange for that spot to go to you.

Semmelweis: Siding with Manus Vindictae is a gamble. Once you go under that mask, most people lose themselves entirely.

Semmelweis: If you come back with me to the Foundation, you'll be safe there.

Lorelei: What is there to be afraid of, my little musical note?

Lorelei: When we first came into this world, we were ignorant and worried about nothing.

Lorelei: We are just returning to our original state.

Lorelei: Is that candy? Why, thank you, Schwab!

Lorelei plucks a non-existent piece of candy from the air in front of her and pops it into her mouth.

Lorelei: It's so sweet, Schwab! It's much sweeter than any candy I've tasted before!

Semmelweis: ...

Bella: Be reasonable, is there any reason to keep trying to communicate with her?

Bella: It is plain as day that it is utterly pointless.

Semmelweis: Forget all that, Lorelei. The only thing I must know is if you have a way for me to complete the "transformation."

Lorelei: ...

Lorelei: Huh? I already told you how, my dear.

Lorelei: Perhaps you didn't hear my voice in the mountains.

Semmelweis: What do you mean? Please, tell me what I must do to complete this "transformation?"

Semmelweis: If you didn't want something from me, why did you leave that song inside my head?

Lorelei: Blessed are those who have not seen and believed.

Lorelei: It seems you still don't understand my song.

Semmelweis: Understand your song ...? What do you mean?

Lorelei: Have a little faith, you will see the meaning within.

Bella: Time to give this up, Semmelweis.

Bella: She's a lunatic.

Bella: There's nothing hidden in her song. She's just a fraud, another in a long line of doomsday prophets with nothing to show for it.

Bella: We should leave. Madam Lindsay is going to notice soon—

Semmelweis: Damn!

Beep beep beep!

Bella: She noticed.

Bella: You know what you must do.

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis: You're right. This was a failure.

Semmelweis composes herself in an instant, turning away from the attention of the Arcanist siren.

Bella: You recover quickly.

Semmelweis: I didn't have a choice. Remorse can come later.

Madam Lindsay: Semmelweis.

Semmelweis: My apologies, Madam Lindsay, I—

Madam Lindsay: Can it. I don't want to hear your excuses. I don't care what you have to say.

Madam Lindsay: Don't think that I don't know what you're up to—This is a serious infraction.

Madam Lindsay: I could have you killed for this, but I've decided to give you one more chance.

Madam Lindsay: Now get to the evacuation point immediately. Do not make me regret this mercy.

Semmelweis: Thank you, Madam Lindsay. I will head there now, Madam. You can expect a full report on my actions.

Madam Lindsay: I don't want you to force my hand, Semmelweis.

Madam Lindsay: The Foundation has already lost enough today. Hofmann is dead.

Semmelweis: Greta is ... dead?

Semmelweis: .....

Semmelweis: I understand. Thank you again. I'm heading to the evacuation point now.

Semmelweis: Greta's death is a surprise to me, she was always so in control.

Bella: She didn't deserve to go out like that.

Bella: If even she can't control her own fate, what was the point of your struggle?

Bella: This was a colossal waste, and a dangerous one.

Bella: We have to get back to the Foundation. We'll just have to take our chance next time.

Semmelweis: There are no more chances ...

Semmelweis: You and I both know that our time is running out. We won't make it to the next "Storm."

Bella: You don't know that, we should put our hopes in the inhibiting serum that Madam Lindsay mentioned.

Semmelweis: The LSCC has more important tasks than dreaming up a life-saving serum for a traitor.

Semmelweis: I never had much hope for it.

Bella: Well, at least you finally understand the way things are. You were so unwilling to admit it.

Bella: There was no fate involved.

Bella: "When the mirror's truth no longer exists, how can one know whether the reflection in the mirror is true or false?"

Bella: From start to finish, all you can do is accept things come what may.

Semmelweis looks up at the sky. The distant rumble of thunder grows closer, as if the "Storm" might start at any moment.

Semmelweis: I have to go.

Lorelei: Leaving so soon? Goodbye, see you later!

Semmelweis: I've wasted too much time coming here.

Semmelweis: The "Storm" is coming. Good luck, Lorelei.

Semmelweis: Forgive me, but I hope we never see each other again. I think I've had enough of Arcanists like you for a lifetime.

Lorelei: Oh, but we'll meet again soon.

Lorelei: You will soon be taken by death, just as I will soon be taken by the "Flood."

Lorelei: It won't be long before we meet in the other world!

Semmelweis: What do you mean?

Lorelei: Because I'll soon be "reversed!"

Semmelweis: ...!

Semmelweis: Aren't you planning to go to Manus Vindictae to avoid it?

Lorelei: Huh? My dear, why would I go to Manus Vindictae?

Lorelei: How could I just leave when so many others are seeking my help?

Semmelweis: But there's no point in helping anyone.

Semmelweis: The "Storm" will be here any moment. Everything you've done will soon be washed away.

Lorelei: "We all eventually return to dust; all of life's efforts wash away in the rain."

Lorelei: Even so, I will be here to help others find redemption.

Semmelweis: Perhaps you'll truly give these refugees the salvation they crave and change their fate. But for me, none of this matters.

Lorelei: But the redemption I speak of has always included you, my dear.

Semmelweis: It's pointless to try to understand the way you Arcanists think.

Semmelweis: You speak like the oracles of old, full of nonsense and half-truths.

Semmelweis: But I know now, you were never able to give me the redemption I was seeking.

Lorelei: I never said I would "give" you redemption, Semmelweis.

Lorelei: Redemption is not something we have the power to give; we can merely help you on your way.

Lorelei: I just want to help you.

Lorelei: Both you and all those who suffer.

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis: I thought that you were only going to help Arcanists.

Lorelei: Mankind and Arcanists alike are children of God. We are two compositions in the same meter. There's no difference between us.

Semmelweis: What if I told you that Valentina is dead?

Semmelweis: Killed by a human's bullet.

Semmelweis: Would you still think that? Could you still help mankind without any qualms?

Lorelei: Oh, what a pity! I'm not sure she was ready for the next world, she had much too much to enjoy in this one.

Lorelei: But I will not grieve. I'll be with her again soon.

???: I'm glad to hear you aren't grieving, Lorelei.

Semmelweis: Valentina?!

Valentina appears from the darkness behind Semmelweis.

Valentina: To see that look on your face, Semmelweis—It's priceless. If only I had time to savor it.

Lorelei: Valentina! I am glad that you have not yet left for the world beyond.

Semmelweis: How did you ...

Semmelweis: Have I fallen into another hallucination. This seems so bizarre.

Valentina: Unlike our dear Lorelei, I have little interest in sacrificing myself for others.

Semmelweis recalls the scene of Valentina's "death".

Semmelweis: You turned yourself into a shadow?

Valentina: It's a simple trick for a vampire. One I will be glad to teach you once you finish your transformation.

Valentina: Besides, it let me watch your reaction, which I must say, was very satisfying.

Valentina: "You d**med thing. You didn't even finish telling me where to find Lorelei!"

Semmelweis: ...

Valentina turns to Lorelei.

Valentina: I must get back to Manus Vindictae. This will probably be our last farewell.

Valentina: It's a shame. I'm afraid I'll never meet anyone quite as interesting as you.

Lorelei: I feel the same, dear Valentina! But don't worry. Perhaps one day I will see you again, if only in my dreams!

Lorelei speaks as if blissfully unaware of her impending death.

Valentina: As for you, Semmelweis. You stand at a final crossroad.

Semmelweis: ...

Bella: What are you doing, Semmelweis?

Bella: You don't believe these two lunatics, do you?

Bella: You think you're taking back control. But all your doing is handing over your fate from the Foundation to these two crazed Arcanists.

Bella: Don't let them deceive you. You're different from them.

Lorelei: But of course we are the same, my dear.

Lorelei: Whether Arcanist or human, our souls are no different.

Lorelei: You must learn to accept all parts of yourself, both rational and emotional. Both ...

Lorelei: Semmelweis and Bella.

Semmelweis: ...?!

Bella: You can hear what I'm saying ...?

Lorelei: Of course, Bella. Of course I can hear what you're saying.

Lorelei: All along, **you've been talking to yourself**.

Valentina: Oh, why spoil all the fun, Lorelei!

Semmelweis & Bella: You mean ... All along, I've been talking to myself?

Semmelweis & Bella: Impossible!

Lorelei: How else could I know your names, my dears?

Semmelweis & Bella: No, that can't be!

Lorelei: Why do you refuse to accept what you are, my little musical note?

Lorelei: You are a beautiful composition. Why should you tear yourself apart?

Semmelweis & Bella: ...

Lorelei: Don't be afraid of your emotions, Semmelweis.

Lorelei: Reason and emotion need not conflict.

Lorelei: Just like Arcanists and mankind, they can live in harmony.

Semmelweis: ...

Bella: I didn't think we'd meet again under such circumstances.

Bella: This is your last chance, Semmelweis.

Bella: There's no going back.

Semmelweis: But first, I think I can answer your question about "fate."

Bella: "When the mirror's truth no longer exists, how can one know whether the reflection in the mirror is true or false?"

Semmelweis: My answer is, when the mirror's truth ceases to exist, the reflection is irrelevant.

Semmelweis: It's just a possibility. An unknowable possibility.

Bella: ...

Semmelweis: You ... no, I've been misinterpreting my desires, Bella.

Semmelweis: All along, my "fate" was an illusion. It's truth was no more real than the reflection.

Semmelweis: The idea of controlling it was not only arrogant, but futile.

Semmelweis: All I can do is base my choices on the information available to me. Just as I've always done.

Semmelweis: To find and grasp these unforeseen "possibilities."

Bella: It looks like you've made your choice.

Semmelweis: Yes. That is my answer.

Bella: I see. Then no one can change your mind. You're always like this.

Semmelweis: We're always like this.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Wish Granted

COL-600908

The "Storm" Is Coming

Semmelweis: Here we are, Lorelei.

Lorelei: ...

Lorelei doesn't answer. She's gazing absently at a spot in the sky, as if there's something intriguing there.

Lorelei: I see beautiful moonlight flowing down like white silk. I should sing for it.

She raises the conch to her lips.

She takes a deep breath and starts to sing.

But no one can hear the song. The silent melody drifts across the empty square.

The mirror in Semmelweis's pocket flashes like a gleam of light caught in the spray of a flowing river.

Then, the song crosses the barrier into reality and reaches Semmelweis's ears.

Semmelweis: This is ... the song I heard in the mountains!

Semmelweis: No, something's different ...

This song sounds clearer. More distinct.

It falls like a stone into water, creating the ripples of a hallucination.

Semmelweis: I see red everywhere ... the white peaks of snowy mountains ... distant boating songs ... What is this?

The once-commonplace hallucination now carries a different meaning.

Semmelweis: The red is ... starting to melt? Wait, I get it! I understand!

In a matter of moments, the drawer of hallucinations opens before Semmelweis.

She sees. She sees the truth that lurks behind the song.

An immense joy washes over her. It's almost overwhelming. But soon, all this joy transforms into peaceful relief.

Her long-cherished wish has been fulfilled. This is the moment of success. It's true ...

Semmelweis: Silence.

Lorelei isn't lying. The way to cure the Beyond Disease and survive the transformation is hidden in her song.

The song itself has no meaning, but it contains a truth that cannot be conveyed through words.

For a mixed-blood arcanist who lacks the gift of arcanum, this truth is not easily understood.

Semmelweis: The world's spirit is growing restless. The "Storm" is coming.

Semmelweis: It must be, else I wouldn't have understood the truth in the song.

Semmelweis's thin arcanist bloodline does not allow her to understand this truth until the "Storm" is near.

Semmelweis: "Expand" the boundaries of spirituality; "embrace" the new arcanist bloodline.

Semmelweis: I never thought the answer would be so simple.

Lorelei: The true answer is always simple, my dear.

Lorelei: Countless threads can be woven into a beautiful dress, but this doesn't mean the threads themselves are complex.

Lorelei is no longer singing, but her song still echoes in Semmelweis's ears.

Lorelei: You've already taken the first step; the vampire bloodline is becoming a part of you.

Semmelweis looks down at the palm of her hand. The pain has vanished, and her hallucinations are gradually fading away. The vampire bloodline's influence is growing more profound.

Semmelweis: At this rate, the transformation will be complete before long.

Madam Lindsay: I'm afraid you'll be disappointed, Semmelweis.

Madam Lindsay's voice cuts through Semmelweis's thoughts.

Semmelweis: Madam Lindsay, your response is more delayed than I expected.

Madam Lindsay: I'm angered by your betrayal.

Madam Lindsay: I suppose you're aware of the implications of your actions.

Semmelweis: I know exactly what I did.

Madam Lindsay: You hid it well. You deceived us all, including me.

There is a rage behind her voice.

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis: Heh ...

Semmelweis smiles softly. It's genuine.

No more pretenses, no more beating around the bush, no more hypocrisy.

Semmelweis: I'm sorry, Madam Lindsay. Very sorry for deceiving you.

Semmelweis: But I'll admit it now. I don't care about the Foundation or their mission for peace. I never did.

Semmelweis: Everything I've done has served to achieve my own ends.

Madam Lindsay: Anyone who betrays the Foundation must pay the price. No exceptions.

With the flash of an array, several personnel in Foundation uniforms appear before Semmelweis and Lorelei.

Razor: Investigator Semmelweis, I never thought that this would be the circumstances of our next meeting.

Razor: I must confess, I bear considerable responsibility for your infection.

Semmelweis: You needn't worry. It's a good thing. In fact, it fulfills a dear wish of mine.

Razor: Neither dying from illness nor dying for betraying the Foundation could be considered "good" by any measure.

Razor: I'm curious. What kind of power have you gained that makes you willing to betray the Foundation? What gives you the courage to speak this way in front of the Special Agent Squad?

Semmelweis: Come see for yourself. What better way to test the results of my transformation than through battle?

Lorelei: I'll help you, little musical note.

Wish Granted

COL-600909

Razor: Phew ... Ugh ...

Razor: I'm surprised. I didn't expect an Infected with such newly acquired arcane skills to last so long against us.

Semmelweis: Heh ... Me neither.

Semmelweis: If it weren't for the Storm Syndrome, I'd have lost long ago.

Razor: Still want to fight? I thought you knew that your failure was just a matter of time.

Semmelweis: Heh ... not necessarily. How much longer can you withstand the Storm Syndrome?

Razor: Let's see who gives out first.

Madam Lindsay: Enough, "Razor." Stop wasting time.

Razor: This is my battlefield, Madam Lindsay. Please don't question my judgment.

Madam Lindsay: I can't let you take this risk. I have another way.

Semmelweis: Ha, you ARE desperate. Are you really going to use it, Madam Lindsay?

Madam Lindsay: I don't want to.

Semmelweis: It would surely affect your political position in the Foundation. The higher-ups will be reluctant to trust a politician who needs to rely on last-resort measures to control her subordinates.

Madam Lindsay: I'd rather not use such means on someone who was once one of my most trusted subordinates.

Madam Lindsay: But I need to take responsibility for the Foundation's "Razor" squad.

Semmelweis: "Scorching Heart"—an arcane skill created by the Field Agent Administration to control the members of the Field Agent Squad.

Semmelweis: If we show signs of betrayal, the Field Agent Administration can activate the arcane skill at any time and eliminate us.

Madam Lindsay: You were doomed to fail from the start.

Madam Lindsay sighs and starts casting the arcane skill.

A scarlet light flashes from Semmelweis's chest, followed by an intense pain.

The smell of burning fills the air as black mist billows from her chest.

Madam Lindsay: I'm sorry it has to end this way, Semmelweis.

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis: No ... not yet.

A pained, indistinct voice comes from within the mist; it's Semmelweis.

Lorelei: You did it!

Semmelweis: Ha ... I should thank Valentina. She gave me the idea.

The black mist disperses to reveal Semmelweis kneeling weakly, covering her chest with her hands.

It's charred and blackened, but there is no doubt that she's still alive.

Madam Lindsay: What?!

Razor: I see. You temporarily transformed your heart into mist to avoid having it incinerated.

Razor: But this arcane skill must've drained your energy. It'll only make you fall faster in battle.

"Razor" steps forward, the weapon in his hand glinting.

Semmelweis: You're right. So, I have a proposal ...

Razor: A proposal?

Madam Lindsay: I won't hear a word. You're a traitor. You can't be trusted.

Razor: Just listen, won't you, Madam Lindsay?

Razor: Maybe she really can come up with a solution. I'd rather not take action against another member of the Foundation.

Madam Lindsay: Let me remind you, "Razor," that from the moment she decided to betray us, she was no longer part of the Foundation—

Madam Lindsay: ...

Madam Lindsay: Hm? Yes, I'm Lindsay ... Have we met?

Madam Lindsay: ...

Madam Lindsay: I understand. It's a logical decision.

Madam Lindsay: Rest assured, I'll be sure to abide by it.

Semmelweis: It seems I'm more valuable than I thought.

Madam Lindsay: The Foundation accepts your proposal.

Semmelweis: At least someone agrees with me. Perhaps my luck isn't so bad after all.

Madam Lindsay: As a living Infected and a field agent who can survive the "Scorching Heart," your value to the Foundation is extremely high.

Madam Lindsay: However, this betrayal of yours will not be written off. You'll still be punished accordingly.

Semmelweis: I accept your terms.

Semmelweis looks at Lorelei.

Semmelweis: But I would also request that the Foundation take in this arcanist. Her arcane skill will be of great research value to the Foundation.

Madam Lindsay: My orders are to bring you back, not any other arcanists.

Semmelweis: ...

Lorelei: Thank you, but that won't be necessary, my dear.

Lorelei: I never wanted to escape from the "Flood."

Semmelweis: Lorelei, you need to live ...

As Semmelweis's eyes meet Lorelei's, she falls silent. She realizes that she cannot convince her.

Lorelei: I'm not leaving. There are still people waiting for my help, including my mother and father.

Lorelei: No, not the hallucinations, but the real Mama and Papa that exist in another world.

Lorelei moves over to Semmelweis, takes off the conch, and gently hangs it around Semmelweis's neck.

Lorelei: See you, Semmelweis.

With a smile to Semmelweis and a wave to the "Razor" Squad, Lorelei leaves without so much as a backward glance.

Semmelweis: Lorelei!

Lorelei is humming and dancing a cheery dance, as if she's on her way to a pleasant dinner party.

Semmelweis: ...

As she watches Lorelei leave, Semmelweis strokes the conch around her neck.

Semmelweis: Madam Lindsay, "Razor," I surrender.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Melody of Dusk

COL-600910

The "Storm" Is Coming

Semmelweis: Here we are, Lorelei.

Lorelei: ...

Lorelei doesn't answer. She's gazing absently at a spot in the sky, as if there's something intriguing there.

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Semmelweis: I never thought the answer would be so simple.

Lorelei: The true answer is always simple, my dear.

Lorelei: Countless threads can be woven into a beautiful dress, but this doesn't mean the threads themselves are complex ...

Lorelei pauses mid-sentence, a rare look of surprise on her face.

Lorelei: Oh my, what's this? How odd!

Semmelweis: What happened?

Lorelei: Something on you is resonating with my song ...

As soon as Lorelei says this, Semmelweis feels the song in her ears beginning to change.

A surge of spirituality pours into her, expanding the boundaries of her spirit.

Semmelweis: Is the transformation ... speeding up?

Semmelweis: Could it be ...? Is it working?

Semmelweis: It seems to be amplifying the effects of your arcane skill.

Semmelweis: Good. At this rate, I'll complete the transformation in no time.

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis seems to remember something. After a moment of silence, she shakes her head with a wry smile.

Semmelweis: Really, this is very unlike me to do.

Semmelweis takes out the item and passes it to Lorelei.

Lorelei: Hmm? What is it, little musical note? Is this a gift for me?

Lorelei: Oh, I don't need gifts anymore! I'll be gone soon. You need this cute little thing much more than I do!

Semmelweis: You want to help all these people who've been driven mad by the Storm Syndrome, don't you?

Lorelei: Of course. I want to help everyone. Them and you.

Semmelweis: Then take it. It'll amplify your arcane skill—let you help more people.

Lorelei: Oh, I see! You're amazing, little musical note. I hadn't even thought about that!

Lorelei: But is this the treasure you found? Mama and Papa told me not to accept overly expensive gifts.

Semmelweis: You helped me. This is just a small token of my thanks.

Their conversation is broken by a commotion arising on the street corner.

Team Member I: Captain, the intel was wrong. The item isn't here!

Team Member II: These deranged soldiers have us surrounded! We can't initiate the teleport ritual!

The two lead figures are wearing Foundation uniforms. One of them is carrying another Foundation member on his back.

The Foundation member on his back has his eyes closed. His face twists and distorts as it begins the transformation into a vivid oil painting.

Behind the pair is a squad of soldiers. In the frenzy caused by the Storm Syndrome, they instinctively attack every living thing they see.

Team Member I: Damn it! Angelo's Storm Syndrome's getting worse. He'll lose his mind before long.

Team Member II: Go, Captain. Leave us.

Razor: No! Just hang on. I'll get you out of this!

Lorelei: Sounds like someone needs our help, little musical note.

Semmelweis: Wait, Lorelei. We don't know what's going on—

Lorelei: I have to help them.

Before Semmelweis can object, Lorelei closes her eyes and softly hums a song.

Now that it's amplified, the calming power of her song is even stronger.

Team Member I: Is that ... singing? How can someone sing at a time like this? Are they insane?!

Team Member II: Hey, wait ... look at Angelo ...

Team Member I: His mania. It's ... lessened.

Even the soldiers fervently pursuing the "Razor" squad gradually grow quiet at the sound of Lorelei's song.

Razor: Wait, are you ... Investigator Semmelweis?

Semmelweis: Are you "Razor?"

Razor: Thanks to you, my team survived the follow-up attack.

Semmelweis: What are you still doing here, "Razor?" The Timekeeper issued a "Storm" warning quite some time ago.

"Razor" hesitates. At last, he shakes his head.

Razor: Since we already failed the mission, I suppose it doesn't matter if I tell you.

Razor: We were ordered to retrieve a stolen treasure formerly held by the Austro-Hungarian Empire.

Razor: But the intel we received was wrong. Not only was the treasure already gone, but a group of soldiers were there looking for it too.

Razor: We clashed with them ... and then we ended up here.

Razor: No matter what, I'll be sure to report your help to the Foundation truthfully, Semmelweis.

Semmelweis: ... I see.

Madam Lindsay: That won't be necessary, "Razor."

Madam Lindsay's cold voice cuts through the air.

Madam Lindsay: Semmelweis has defected. Eliminate her immediately.

Razor: What's she talking about, Semmelweis?

Semmelweis: The situation's a little complicated, but we aren't enemies, "Razor."

Semmelweis: If I were, why would I let Lorelei help your men?

"Razor" glances at Angelo lying on the ground. He quickly makes a decision.

Razor: Madam Lindsay, you're not my boss. You have no authority over me.

Razor: If Semmelweis really needs to be eliminated, you'll have to submit an application to my boss before I execute the order.

Razor: Until that time, she's still a member of the Foundation.

Madam Lindsay: "Razor," by shielding her, you're creating additional risks for the Foundation.

Madam Lindsay: But I'll have to file a complaint against your irrational behavior later. First, I need to solve the current problem.

Razor: Wait, what's that?!

"Razor's" expression suddenly changes.

The sound of footsteps and horses neighing hits Semmelweis's ears. She turns to see a group of soldiers pushing a cannon on the other side of the street.

The cannon ruthlessly rolls over the soldiers lying on the ground, crushing them into scattered blobs of paint.

Razor: Are those the soldiers from earlier?

Madam Lindsay: A heavy howitzer ... how did that get here?!

"Razor" looks at the pursuers, then at the members of his team who have lost the ability to fight.

Finally, his gaze falls on Semmelweis. It takes only a moment for him to make up his mind.

Razor: Madam Lindsay, I'm sorry, but we need Semmelweis's strength right now.

Razor: Without her combat abilities, we will surely suffer significant casualties.

Madam Lindsay: ...

Madam Lindsay: I understand. Now is not the time to deal with Semmelweis.

Madam Lindsay: You and your subordinates have done nothing wrong. I cannot abandon innocent Foundation members.

Razor: Thank you, Madam Lindsay.

Razor: Semmelweis, I think you heard our conversation.

Razor: I'll appeal to the Foundation on your behalf to reduce your charges. But in return, you must help me defeat these soldiers.

Semmelweis looks at Lorelei, who is sitting idle.

Lorelei turns and smiles at her.

Semmelweis: A wise decision, "Razor." I accept your proposal. I don't want to see our colleagues die under this monster's cannon fire either.

Lorelei: Alright, alright. Let me help you!

Melody of Dusk

COL-600911

Razor: Phew ... Ugh ...

Razor: Nicely done, Semmelweis.

Lorelei: Oh, my friends! I'm so happy for you! You did it!

Razor: Although it's clear you were holding back. Still, I couldn't have done it without you.

Semmelweis: Forgive me, I need to save some energy in case I have to deal with the "Scorching Heart" arcane skill.

Madam Lindsay: I won't do that. That would be tantamount to abandoning my colleagues in their time of need.

Semmelweis: Actually, I'd prefer to take matters into my own hands, Madam Lindsay.

Semmelweis: Need I remind you how you used the Field Agent Squads?

Madam Lindsay: That was a necessary tactic.

Madam Lindsay: Either way, you should be grateful.

Madam Lindsay: I just received an order from the higher-ups at the Foundation.

Madam Lindsay: The order states that I'm to take you and the arcanist called Lorelei back to the Foundation.

Madam Lindsay: Wasn't that your goal, Semmelweis?

Semmelweis: I simply demonstrated my and Lorelei's worth to the Foundation—a living Infected and an arcanist with a unique arcane skill ...

Semmelweis: The Foundation would never give up such outstanding research subjects.

Madam Lindsay: You were in the right place at the right time. Helping the "Razor" Squad has absolved you of some of your guilt. This order wouldn't have been made otherwise.

Semmelweis: Then, may I consider myself reconciled with the Foundation, Madam Lindsay?

Madam Lindsay: Of course.

Lorelei: Oh, this is wonderful, little musical note! You've got your friends back!

Lorelei: I have all kinds of friends, too. Even now, they're all around me!

Lorelei: But I'm very sorry. I know you're trying to help me, but I can't go to the Foundation.

Lorelei: There are still things I must do. Right, Mama and Papa?

Semmelweis: Don't worry, Lorelei.

Semmelweis pulls an item out of Lorelei's pocket.

Razor: What ...?! What's that doing here?!

Semmelweis: So this IS the treasure you were looking for?

Semmelweis: "Razor," I offer you a trade.

Semmelweis: I'll give you this.

Semmelweis: But in return, "Razor" Squad must give asylum to the members of my Field Agent Squad and as many civilians as possible.

Madam Lindsay: What an unwise decision. If you hand that over to the Foundation without fuss, all your previous wrongdoings will be forgiven.

Madam Lindsay: When did you become so soft?

Semmelweis: ... I never really cared about these people.

Lorelei: But you do now, right? Well done, my dear. You must've realized what a joy it is to help others!

Semmelweis: No. I'm afraid I've never found an ounce of pleasure in helping anyone.

Semmelweis: I'm just a selfish person.

Lorelei: But you ARE helping them! You shouldn't put yourself down like that.

Semmelweis: I'm only helping them because that's what you want.

Semmelweis: To me, they're just pawns—to ensure I get you.

Semmelweis: If you don't come to the Foundation with me, I'll change my mind and leave these people to fend for themselves.

Semmelweis: And, yes, that's a threat.

Lorelei: Oh, so that's your plan!

Lorelei tilts her head, thinking carefully.

Lorelei: Mama, Papa, what do you think I should do?

She looks off into the empty space before her, earnestly asking for her hallucinations' advice.

Lorelei: But if I leave here with the little musical note, I'll never see you again.

Lorelei: The "Flood" will wash away all traces of our lives, and the world I face will be totally different.

Lorelei: ...

Lorelei: Hmm, I suppose that makes sense ...

Lorelei: But Mama's right. You'll always be with me in my hallucinations.

Lorelei: If that's the case, I shouldn't stay in this valley, right?

Lorelei's question isn't directed at her hallucinations but at the silent Semmelweis beside her.

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis: Right. Only by surviving will you have the chance to see a more beautiful and memorable valley, Lorelei.

Lorelei: Alright. I'll go with you, my dear!

Lorelei: Goodbye, Mama! Goodbye, Papa!

Thanks to Lorelei's arcane skill, the previously crazed members of the "Razor" Squad are calmed. They fall into a deep sleep.

A familiar voice echoes from the communication device.

Madam Lindsay: Semmelweis, do you have a moment to talk?

Semmelweis: Of course, Madam Lindsay.

Madam Lindsay: I'm sorry for lying to you about Laplace.

Madam Lindsay: But I have no regrets. As a member of the Foundation, I must do everything I can to preserve its strength.

Semmelweis: I understand your motives, Madam Lindsay.

Semmelweis: You hid the truth of the situation from me, just as I hid my true intentions from you.

Semmelweis: In that regard, we're even.

Madam Lindsay: In any case, I should congratulate you for surviving.

Semmelweis: As my superior?

Madam Lindsay: No, on a personal level. As a member of the Foundation, I have no comment on the matter.

Madam Lindsay: I also want to congratulate you on saving that little girl and those humans ... That wasn't like you.

Semmelweis: People change all the time, Madam Lindsay.

Semmelweis: Honestly, when Lorelei made the decision, I was relieved.

Semmelweis: I really had no clue which way she would go ... Ha, you never can know what an arcanist lunatic is thinking.

Madam Lindsay: You're not much different.

Madam Lindsay: Oh, and I suppose one last round of congratulations is in order. You are now a true arcanist—an arcanist I cannot understand.

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis: Thank you.

THE END

The Mirrored Embrace

COL-600912

The "Storm" Is Coming

Semmelweis: Here we are, Lorelei.

Lorelei doesn't answer. She's gazing intently at a spot in the sky, as if intrigued by something there.

Lorelei: The moonlight is flowing down like white silk. I'd like to sing to it.

She raises the conch to her lips.

A deep breath hangs in her lungs, and then, she sings.

But no one can hear her. The silent melody drifts across an empty square.

The mirror in Semmelweis's pocket flashes with a gleam of light.

Then, the song crosses into reality and finds its way to Semmelweis's ears.

Semmelweis: That's ... the song I heard in the mountains!

Semmelweis: No, something's different.

Madam Lindsay: It's been too long since our last call, Semmelweis.

An emotionless voice breaks the moment. The song fades, and Semmelweis is dragged back to her senses.

Madam Lindsay: I'm very eager to know why you still haven't evacuated.

Semmelweis: My apologies, Madam Lindsay. I ran into this arcanist by the river, and she's special.

Semmelweis: The arcane skill she wields with her voice can pacify Storm Syndrome victims, though I can't say I understand how it works.

Semmelweis: I believe the Foundation should take her in. Please allow me to evacuate with her.

Madam Lindsay: An arcanist? You're telling me you violated our regulations several times over and even disobeyed a direct order just to save a stranger?

Madam Lindsay: Semmelweis, out of my deepest respect for your work and loyalty, I'll give you one last chance.

Madam Lindsay: Evacuate Vienna immediately. The Foundation has neither the time nor manpower to assess the value of this arcanist.

Semmelweis: Heh. Sorry, I'll have to disobey your orders yet again.

Madam Lindsay: Let me stress this point again. Do you know what you're about to do?

Semmelweis: I do. You've made a miscalculation, Madam Lindsey. You thought I obeyed your orders out of loyalty. No, I followed orders because they worked in my interest.

Semmelweis: Now they don't.

Madam Lindsay sighs as she casts an arcane skill.

A scarlet light flashes from Semmelweis's chest, radiating intense pain.

Madam Lindsay: You've chosen to make us your enemy to serve your own interests. You chose poorly. The Foundation does not tolerate betrayal.

Scorching Heart—an arcane skill created by the Field Agent Administration to control its agents.

In case of betrayal, the Field Agent Administration can activate this arcane skill at any time to eliminate them.

Madam Lindsay: I'm sorry it has to end this way, Semmelweis.

Semmelweis: No ...

A puff of black mist escapes from her chest. Semmelweis collapses to her knees, clutching at her heart with her hand.

Valentina: Valentina walks out of the mist with a smile on her face.

Valentina: And let my joy leave the stage so early? I couldn't bear it! After all, the show must go on.

Semmelweis: You ...

Lorelei: Valentina, little musical note! I'm so glad you made it!

Valentina: You did well preserving that flower.

Affected by the arcane skill, the "Gruß an Aachen" begins to wither from the heat.

Valentina: Looks like you've decided to accept my terms.

Valentina: We're "in sync" after all, Semmelweis.

Semmelweis: Thank you for that, but I've not made a decision yet.

Valentina: Oh?

Semmelweis: Tell me how to survive the transformation first.

Valentina: A reasonable request. As you wish.

Valentina: The answer lies in ... Lorelei's song.

Semmelweis: Lorelei's song? I knew it.

Semmelweis: You put that note in my pocket and waited for me here. All this was part of your plan.

Valentina: You really are such a joy, Semmelweis.

Valentina: You're rational, quick-witted, and always hold your ground no matter the situation.

Valentina: I know you'll always choose what's best for you, and you will again this time.

Valentina: Come with me. Heinrich is waiting for us.

The Mirrored Embrace

COL-600913

Backstage, Vienna People's Opera

The hysteria of the era, all the twisted bodies, chaotic scenes, and feverish minds are hidden behind the golden curtain.

Valentina: Here we are. Looks like Heinrich hasn't arrived yet.

Semmelweis: I have no time to waste. Can we start right away, Lorelei?

Lorelei: Certainly, if you believe it will help, my dear.

Lorelei steps onto the stage, fingers crossed, eyes closed, and begins to sing.

The song is identical to the one that Semmelweis had heard before. Her voice is like the waves of the sea or the stars in the sky.

A moment of clarity and peace ... but that's all. The expected transformation doesn't come.

Semmelweis: Nothing's happening.

In a desperate attempt, she recites the incantation again.

Semmelweis: Scarlatum!

Valentina offers a glimmer of a smile beneath her waiting eyes. The incantation has done nothing.

Semmelweis: I just need to calm down and try again.

Semmelweis: Scarlatum!

Still, nothing happens.

Lorelei: My dear, it seems you still don't **understand** my song.

Semmelweis: What?

Lorelei: You're trying to give meaning to the melody,

Lorelei: memorizing every note and searching for words that never existed.

Lorelei: Notes are only notes, my dear. They need no interpretation. We must accept them for what they are.

Valentina: Enough, Lorelei. You've done all that you can.

Valentina: I'll take you to Manus Vindictae. We can complete the transformation in a more direct way.

Semmelweis: Heh. You mean put on that "mask" so I can become another one of your puppets? You're a bad saleswoman, you know.

Valentina: Of course not. You won't do me any good as a walking beast.

Valentina: My terms have never changed: we'll work together and secure a place in Manus Vindictae.

Semmelweis: You seem sure that I'll accept your "offer."

Valentina: Well, it appears to me that you've turned your back on the Foundation for good; that means there's no more help coming for you. If you want to survive the "Storm" ...

Valentina: I don't think you have a choice.

Semmelweis: No, Valentina.

Semmelweis: I won't let you manipulate me. I know you as well as any of your kind. Trusting you is the last thing I'd do.

Semmelweis: Be honest; all you've ever wanted is a tool. And I'm not interested.

A round of applause echoes on the stage.

Valentina: Brava!

Valentina: You never fail to surprise me with your insights, Semmelweis. I had no idea you saw my offer that way.

Valentina: But you're wrong about one thing.

She steps closer to Semmelweis confidently.

Valentina: Did you ever consider that flower was left on the table for a reason?

For a moment, just one instant, Semmelweis is astonished. Valentina responds with a look of pure satisfaction.

Valentina: And remember ...

Valentina: There are limits to what reason can explain.

Valentina: I look forward to seeing you again one day. Don't forget it was me who saved your life today, Semmelweis.

Valentina: But nothing's for certain.

Valentina bends over and takes the "Gruß an Aachen" from her.

Valentina: Fate will bring us together again if that is what it wills.

The Mirrored Embrace

COL-600914

Time passes, and thick streams of paint in a rainbow of colors begins to leak through the ceiling to the ground, twisting everything it touches.

Semmelweis: The "Storm" is coming.

Semmelweis opens her bag, pouring everything out.

Exhila Ritual, Condensed Belladonna Juice, Resounding Rifle, Life Insurance Policy, Proof of Poise ...

Nothing in her bag will help her survive the "Storm."

Semmelweis: The "Storm" will completely reverse everything in ...

She reaches into her pocket, trying to find something that can tell the time.

Semmelweis: Hmm? What?

Semmelweis: My mirror! It's moving?

She raises the mirror to catch its reflection, yet ...

Semmelweis&Bella: There's nothing there.

Semmelweis can feel herself melting, blending into the paint that falls from the sky, while the stage turns into an empty palette.

Inside the chaos, where everything becomes one, she sees someone familiar.

Semmelweis: Bella.

Bella: We meet again, Semmelweis.

Semmelweis: I seldom like to use words like "intuition" or "feeling."

Semmelweis: But I had a feeling that you'd be the last thing I'd meet before I die.

Semmelweis&Bella: So you know we don't have much time left.

Bella: And yet, you still don't regret the choices you've made, even now?

Semmelweis: I'm sure you already know my answer. Don't we know each other well enough by now?

Bella: Do we?

Semmelweis: Because ... asking what's right or wrong—that's never been how I decide things. There's only one factor: what's best for me.

Semmelweis turns her back to the stage and raises her hand.

Semmelweis: There's only one thing left for me to do—try again.

Semmelweis: Scarlatum!

A fire flares up in the center of the stage and then extinguishes just as fast. Though only a momentary flash, Semmelweis is certain that it was not an illusion.

Semmelweis: I ... I did that?

Bella: You sound surprised. What happened to all that bravado?

Bella stands up and raises her hand, matching Semmelweis's movements.

Bella: Scarlatum!

The same fire is conjured again, with the same heat and the same arcane fluctuation.

Bella: Look, Semmelweis. You've done it.

Bella: From the mountain to the river, and now the stage, we've traveled a long way just to pursue the possibility of mastering our arcane skill.

Bella: The Foundation, Manus Vindictae, Valentina, Lorelei ... We've turned to everyone that could've helped us.

Bella walks close to Semmelweis, her eyes ***crimson***.

She raises a mirror, the one that hadn't reflected their image.

Bella: You said, "When the mirror's truth ceases to exist, the reflection is irrelevant."

Bella: But it looks like some mirrors still reflect us.

Bella drops the mirror, letting it shatter on the ground.

Bella: Look into my eyes now, like you looked into that mirror.

The Mirrored Embrace

COL-600915

Semmelweis: Myself.

Semmelweis: I saw myself.

Bella: That's right, Semmelweis. You can still see your reflection in these "mirrors."

Bella: They accept you just as you are, reflecting all your absurdity, your mistakes, and your possibilities. They're always honest and will remain so evermore, just as I do.

Semmelweis: Honest, you? Really?

Semmelweis: No. It's me. I will remain honest to myself.

Semmelweis breaks free from Bella's eyes yet finds her hand holding Bella's the next moment.

Bella: And who do you think you are?

Semmelweis: I ... I don't feel like defining myself, not with any words I've ever known.

Semmelweis: I've spent too much time caught between humans and arcanists, trying to understand their rules and bend them to my advantage.

Semmelweis: But now I realize that I've never achieved what I actually want. I've never been accepted by either side, or even by myself.

Semmelweis&Bella: That's why no mirror would ever reflect "us" in real life.

Semmelweis: But things have changed.

The boundary between them is fading away.

Bella: I have been looking at you all this time.

Bella: When you were looking at the rules, faking a smile, running around like a headless chicken, trying to turn into a "real" arcanist ... I never stopped looking.

Bella: Because I knew the moment you looked into my eyes ...

Semmelweis&Bella: "We" would be back on the right track.

Bella's figure thins out, passing through the invisible boundary that had once been unbreakable in Semmelweis's mind.

Bella: You've found "**us**."

Semmelweis hears her own heart beating in silence, pumping new blood to every corner of her body.

Semmelweis: That's the answer I've been looking for. It's just "me."

Semmelweis walks down from the stage.

She has never hesitated when breaking with the past.

Team Member I: Captain, our intel was wrong. The item isn't here!

Team Member II: These deranged soldiers have us surrounded! We can't initiate the teleport ritual!

Semmelweis: Is that ... "Razor" and his squad?

Semmelweis: Perhaps I still have something the Foundation wants.

Semmelweis's story is far from over.

The Ultimate Joy

COL-600916

Valentina: Our little art appreciation tour of Vienna is just about over.

The lurking vampire has shown herself right on cue, dragging the story toward its final act.

Valentina: It's nearly time for our rendezvous with Manus Vindictae. Best not be late. They can be as paranoid as the Foundation, worse even.

Valentina: Tell me, Semmelweis—will you join me?

Valentina: Or do you still intend to place your faith in little Lorelei? Betting your future on a song?

Lorelei: No.

With that soft reply, the girl in restraints shakes her head. The unbuckled straps sway with the motion.

Lorelei: It's time I said goodbye to my dear little musical note.

A line no one expects, bringing on a shocked lull to their conversation.

Valentina: How ... unexpected. I'm glad to hear it; only why now? I thought you were worried about her condition.

Lorelei: Of course, I love my little musical note! Every musical note!

Lorelei: That's why I mustn't play favorites. There are so many other musical notes that need help. Isn't that right, Mama? Papa?

Semmelweis: Do you both intend to continue discussing this as if I'm not even here? I haven't decided to go with anyone.

Lorelei: No one intends to decide for you, my little musical note. You're free—you always have been. Free to help whoever you want.

Lorelei: Oh, Papa, why have you tapped my shoulder? Out of time, so soon? Ah, of course, we must leave right away!

Lorelei: Sorry, my little musical note. Sorry, Valentina. I must leave you.

Lorelei: The "Flood" is coming. I need to gather everyone, or else we'll be swept apart.

Lorelei: I thank you both for bringing me here. Godspeed to you both. Until we meet again ... in another world.

With the splash of her steps in the puddles, Lorelei turns and walks toward her riverbank.

Valentina: I see. Well, then the only question remains whether you are still intent on reviewing your options.

Valentina: My offer stands. My hand is outstretched, if you'll take it.

Semmelweis: ...

A sigh and a flicker of resolve form on her lips as Semmelweis locks eyes with the vampire before her.

Semmelweis: I've said I'll consider it—but first you need to tell me how to complete the transformation.

Semmelweis: And I won't be wearing that mask.

Valentina: How long have I been waiting to hear you say those words? Wonderful, then you must accompany me to the opera house. Manus Vindictae should have control of it by now—there we will complete your transformation.

The Ultimate Joy

COL-600917

The hysteria of the era, all the twisted bodies, chaotic scenes, and feverish minds are hidden behind the golden curtain.

Valentina: Something's happened to Heinrich. He wouldn't be this late.

Valentina: I do hope he's alive. I had intended for him to help me show the sincerity of Manus Vindictae's offer, after all.

Semmelweis: Could be that your Heinrich's been shot in some alley on his way here. Given the state Vienna's in, I wouldn't be surprised.

Semmelweis: Forget him. I don't have time to spare on your demonstrations of sincerity. Can we just begin?

Valentina: Tsk. So impatient, my pet. You'll soon have more time than you know what to do with.

Madam Lindsay: Begin what, exactly? Miss Semmelweis?

A familiar voice cuts in over the comm, tinged with anger.

Madam Lindsay: I think we can skip the explanation. I warned you again and again, and you still chose to ignore my orders.

Madam Lindsay: You leave me no choice.

A scarlet light flashes from Semmelweis's chest, radiating out a blast of intense pain.

Madam Lindsay: I'll be submitting a full report shortly, including a record of this conversation, and the part where your repeated insubordination earned you a Scorching Heart strike.

Madam Lindsay: I'm sorry it has to end this way, Semmelweis.

Semmelweis: Lindsay! You ...

As Semmelweis collapses from the pain, Valentina kneels beside her, a teasing smile on her lips as she rests a hand over the smoldering spot on Semmelweis's chest.

Valentina: Calm yourself. I won't let this be your end. It isn't time to exit the stage just yet.

Valentina: Hmm? What?

For the first time, her smile fades. Genuine surprise flickers over her gray face.

Valentina: You've already completed your transformation ...

Black mist billows out from Semmelweis's chest, erasing even the acrid scent of scorched flesh.

As it clears, Semmelweis stares up with a look of similar surprise and confusion.

Madam Lindsay: What?

Semmelweis: What ... just happened? Valentina?

Valentina: Don't give me that look. I'm afraid this isn't the surprise I had intended for you.

Valentina: Someone else must have helped you complete the process. But who?

???: Der Gipfel des Berges funkelt,

The familiar melody sounds from somewhere close.

Valentina: You've been carrying the shell with you this whole time? Of course ... such an obvious answer.

Valentina: Lorelei can hear you through that shell; it stands to reason that you would be able to hear her too.

Valentina: I wouldn't count on it getting anything else from it. You've used up all her blessings.

Semmelweis: Lorelei ... she was helping me all this time?

Valentina: Think back. When's the last time you spoke with your inner voice?

Semmelweis: ... Bella?

Semmelweis: Are you there?

Her irksome shadow is silent—not even a twitch of thought or muscle. As if she never existed at all.

Valentina: After being exposed to Lorelei's song for so long, even a thick-skulled rock like you would embrace a little emotion.

Valentina: I suppose congratulations are in order. We walk the same path now, you and I.

Semmelweis: That's it? That was easier than I expected.

Semmelweis feels for the fading burn in her chest, struggling to find its familiar pain.

Semmelweis: Lindsay, you're still listening, aren't you?

Madam Lindsay: I have nothing more to say to a traitor. And I see no reason to listen to one, either.

Semmelweis: Won't you let me explain? Just a few words from someone who wandered, trying to survive—trying to find a future.

Madam Lindsay: ...

Semmelweis: Your "Laplace research updates" on my condition were always just to placate me. I've known that for a while.

Semmelweis: And yes, I freely admit it—I've weighed my options between the Foundation and Manus Vindictae to determine which offered me the best chance at survival.

Semmelweis: I admit, once I learned that being the Infected would grant me arcane skills, I began to lean toward Manus Vindictae.

Madam Lindsay: And now you're a full-fledged arcanist.

Madam Lindsay: So what? Are you about to have a change of heart and beg to come back to the Foundation?

Semmelweis: It seems like the right thing to do. Are you saying my little heartfelt confession failed to move you even a little?

Semmelweis: But if you refuse, then it seems there is only one way left—to turn to Manus Vindictae. Setting all other benefits aside, I would have preferred the Foundation. What a shame.

Madam Lindsay: Hmph. A fully transformed Infected ... I know that the researchers at Laplace would love to run a full analysis on you. Fine.

Madam Lindsay: More than anything else, I can't have a powerful asset like you join Manus Vindictae. Insubordinate or not.

Semmelweis: I knew you'd see reason. Lindsay, I've got another request. Will you hear me out?

Madam Lindsay: One. You get one.

Semmelweis: I want your permission to bring in a group of refugees and an arcanist with a unique ability.

Madam Lindsay: I'm going to need a justification. You know I can't authorize entry for unknown individuals ...

Semmelweis: This arcanist has the ability to suppress the Storm Syndrome, and those refugees are leverage to convince her to join us.

Semmelweis: And maybe it doesn't matter to you, but she's the reason I'm still alive. Leaving her to die would ruin my mood. I'm sure you wouldn't want that. Think of her as a friend of mine—or better yet, family.

Madam Lindsay: I almost thought you'd be harder to understand after becoming an arcanist; seems I was wrong.

Madam Lindsay: Maybe it's a good thing, letting a bit of arcanist passion temper that cold, calculating heart of yours.

Madam Lindsay: Go. Help your friend. We'll deal with the paperwork later. But you must return to the evacuation point before the "Storm" hits, and you will be facing punishment for this insubordination.

The comm goes fizzles out, leaving two vampires standing in a silent opera house.

Then, the quiet is broken with a clap, then another, in a mocking cadence.

Valentina: What a touching heart-to-heart. So, that's it then; you won't be joining me after all?

Semmelweis: It's a simple calculation. Between you and the Foundation, the latter offers me a better deal. Besides, you didn't exactly hold up your end of the bargain with my transformation, did you?

Valentina: That deadpan wit of yours—it's sharper than any wooden stake, you know? I may just cry.

Valentina: Ah well, I lost to Lorelei this round. But I have a feeling we'll be seeing each other again very soon.

Semmelweis: I sincerely hope your feeling is wrong.

Valentina: When you've lived as long as I have, feelings like these tend to be ... uncannily accurate. Believe me.

Two black clouds drift out of the opera house in opposite directions.

The Ultimate Joy

COL-600918

Semmelweis runs along the river of the "Storm." Her new vampiric body feels light, powerful. No more checking the mirror—she knows now she's survived.

She has time to do more than just stay alive. She can finally pursue something beyond survival.

And at last, she arrives.

There is no concern with finding Lorelei. The girl in restraints stands atop a raised platform, surrounded by a halo of color—the only calm amidst the chaos along the river.

Semmelweis: Lorelei, what are you—

But things are never that simple.

The platform beneath Lorelei is lifted by her believers—a human scaffold, raising her to a perilous height.

Her song continues, holding open a small, still void in a sea of paint. But the tide is rising, and that void is about to collapse into a whirlpool.

Semmelweis: I need you to come with me, Lorelei.

Semmelweis: I secured us a place with the Foundation—for you and your friends. No one will be reversed.

Lorelei: Little musical note?

Semmelweis: Yes, it's me. We've done it. Think of it as a reward for helping me. Please, come back to the Foundation with me—

Lorelei: Mama, look! The little black horse has come! It really rode in on the "Flood"!

Semmelweis: Ah ... the joys of arcanist conversation ... Lorelei, are you still in there?

Lorelei: Come, little horse, little horse, hop up and join us. Soon sorrow and sadness will fill this place. Join our prayer.

Semmelweis: The "Storm" is clouding your mind, your judgment. At least you're not getting violent like the others, little victories, right?

Semmelweis: Snap out of it. We're out of time. If you don't, I'll have to get rough.

Lorelei: Why won't you answer me? Is your heart already dead?

Lorelei: That's okay, my little musical note. We can still be friends; but let's stay here together for a little while.

The Ultimate Joy

COL-600919

Semmelweis: *pant*

Surprised to discover that even vampires can lose their breath climbing up a scaffolding, Semmelweis reaches the top of the platform and delicately grabs Lorelei's hand—only to yank her out from the crowd.

Semmelweis: It's Semmelweis! I'm not your horse or your "little musical note," understood?

Lorelei: Semmelweis?

Her singing halts. The believers scattered around her freeze, waiting for her to continue.

Semmelweis: You're finally back.

Semmelweis: I need you to get these people moving. We can still make it to the Foundation.

Time is tight, but it'll work. As long as she holds Lorelei's hand, the others will follow.

She can save her own life—and the one who gave her hope.

Alive and in good spirits—what could be better?

Lorelei: Little—Semmelweis? Slow down, you're walking too fast. There are stones in the path ahead.

Is she still riding the rush of battle? Or is this some kind of delayed exhilaration from being reborn?

Semmelweis keeps adjusting her pace to match Lorelei and the others. Slower ... slower ...

Slower, slower, slower, slower, slow—

Her consciousness fades into black mist.

Valentina: You really should learn to trust me. My intuitions are always on point.

Valentina: Don't worry, little Lorelei. Our pet's just a little overexcited from her transformation. She'll be right as rain, soon enough.

Valentina: No, no—there's nothing you can do with that cloud of mist. It's better you leave her to me.

Valentina: And you'd best not waste her goodwill. Otherwise, well ... I suspect it would "really ruin her mood."

Valentina: The Foundation's that way. Keep going, and you might just make it.

When Semmelweis wakes, she's lying flat with Valentina peering down. The back of her head feels stiff and cold.

Valentina: Finally awake? Sleep well? A thousand pardons—I couldn't find a fluffy pillow for you.

Semmelweis: You knew this would happen.

Valentina: Perhaps I did, but then again, I didn't hold up my end of the bargain, did I?

There's no time for another pointless debate. Semmelweis scrambles up to her feet, intent on running to the Foundation.

Valentina: You won't make it, I'm afraid. Now, only I can shelter you from the "Storm." Will you come with me?

One simple sentence stops her cold. She turns, trying to pierce the smiling old vampire with her glare.

Semmelweis: No mask.

Valentina: Do you see me wearing one?

Semmelweis: *sigh*

Valentina: You were much more entertaining when you were desperate to survive, Semmelweis.

Valentina: I've already sent the guards away. Will you please just relax?

Semmelweis: I've completely lost contact with the Foundation, sitting in a secret Manus Vindictae safehouse, riding out the "Storm" with one of their vampires ...

Semmelweis: Could I still report back to the Foundation? What would I tell them—how much would I tell them? Even if I begged Madam Lindsay to cover for me ... Would she?

Semmelweis: *sigh*

Valentina: The offer still stands, Semmelweis.

Semmelweis: And I still refuse it. Whatever punishment awaits me with the Foundation will still be worth it compared to the cost of joining Manus Vindictae.

Valentina: Then forget Manus Vindictae. Whether he's lying dead in some alleyway or simply ditched us, Heinrich won't be coming here. Nor will anyone else for that matter. I'd say our deal has been broken—unilaterally.

Valentina: First, you, then, Heinrich. This Vienna trip seems to be one betrayal after another.

Valentina: But enough of that; I'm inviting you into something else entirely—consider it an afternoon tea party for vampires only. So far, it's just the two of us.

Semmelweis: And what do I stand to gain from being your partner?

Valentina: Did you expect something in return when you helped our little Lorelei? You risked everything for her safety, purely out of goodwill.

Valentina: Won't you spare just a tenth of that goodwill for me? Be my friend?

Semmelweis: Helping someone like Lorelei makes me happy. That's what I get out of it. Being friends with you ... I'm not sure if that would bring me anything close to joy.

Valentina: So full of hate. What if I were to disappear right now—would that make you feel better?

Semmelweis: Watching someone vanish into the "Storm" before my eyes would do nothing to improve my mood. So no, please don't.

Valentina: And what does it matter? Whether the "Storm" takes us back ten years or a hundred, there's likely to be a version of me there—only short a few years.

Valentina: For the world, and for me ... it isn't so much of a loss.

Semmelweis: What a wonderfully novel hypothesis. I'm sure Laplace would name it after you in their next report.

Valentina: So—back to our tea party. Are you sure you don't want to stay and join me?

Semmelweis: You say it's an invitation; I assume I have the right to decline?

Valentina: Naturally, my dear. But there's still some time yet before the "Storm" ends—so I hope you won't mind my trying to convince you.

Semmelweis: So this is the price of survival—enduring the nagging of a vampire in some dusty old place.